A GRIMOIRE OF THE OLD RELIGIONS · VOL. II

The Celtic Grimoire

A journal of land, season,
ancestor & craft

Black-ink edition · 6 × 9 in · 150 pages

DEDICATION

For the ones who kept the wells clean
and the doors open.

Write your own dedication below.

Contents

1. Threshold · 7–14

2. Otherworld Next Door · 15–30

3. Gods & Neighbors · 31–60

4. Heroes & Your Geis · 61–74

5. Wheel of Four Fires · 75–98

6. Plants of Medicine & Ritual · 99–118

7. Wells, Fords, Doorways, Dawn & Dusk · 119–132

8. Charms & Protective Workings · 133–142

9. Ancestors & the Dead · 143–147

10. Your Oath · 148–150

How to use this book

Come in and make yourself at home, because this book works the way a good visit does. You read a little and then you do a little, and then you write a little, and that rhythm carries the whole book. Short passages open each part while the practices fit inside an hour, and the lined pages take the rest, so date every entry and watch your year turn in your own hand.

Take safety as part of the welcome and keep it always. Safety first, always. Never ingest yew, mistletoe, or selago in any form. No wild plant identification without an expert beside you — store-bought teas only. Check every herb against your medicines and, if relevant, pregnancy with a clinician. Never leave flame unattended.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *What season is it today, outside your actual window? Name three signs.*

MAP

Three windows

Gaul — roughly today's France and beyond: hillforts, the Coligny bronze, short votive inscriptions in a Celtic tongue, gods known mostly by name and image.

Ireland — the four fires, the Tuatha De Danann, the Ulster heroes, Brehon laws, wells still visited: stories written down by Christians, customs kept by families.

Wales — the Mabinogi's four branches, Annwn the deep place, Rhiannon's birds: a smaller window, and no less strange for it.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Mark your own spot on the map in words. Where do you stand, reading this?*

YOURS

This grimoire belongs to ___ . I open it on ___ , intending ___ .

THRESHOLD

Who we mean here, part one

Picture a family of languages rather than a single tribe, scattered from hillforts and salt mines to river towns where traders set up altars. The earliest kin gather around the salt workings at Hallstatt, where timber stairs still stain dark with brine, and later metalworkers at La Tène wind animal shapes into bronze and gold that ripple when you turn them in lamplight. Centuries afterward Gaulish farmers carve short prayers to local gods in stone under Rome, and Irish and Welsh scribes copy old stories into Christian manuscripts by candlelight. Cousins, not twins.

Keep Gaul, Ireland, and Wales as three windows on related but separate houses, and look through one at a time. In the Gaulish window you meet Epona, named on soldiers' dedications from Britain to Bulgaria with almost no story attached — Attested, but spare. In the Welsh window rides Rhiannon on a white horse no rider can catch, from medieval tales — Attested there. In the Irish window stands the Dagda with his club and cauldron, generous and crude in the same hour, from medieval manuscripts too. Kin in speech, distinct in household.

You do not need blood or belief to begin here, only an honest address. Tonight pick one window and stay with it for half an hour at your table: read one short passage, write down which house you visited and one name you greeted, and close the book. Naming the household keeps you courteous. The rest of this book will keep reminding you which door you knocked on.

Lore Root: language family plus archaeology (Hallstatt/La Tene) plus Gaulish stones plus medieval manuscripts — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Tell me which of the three windows calls to you first, Gaul or Ireland or Wales, and say what pulls you toward it.*

Who we mean here, part two

This book makes no secret of its limits, and you deserve them plainly before you give it your year. No druid ever wrote down teachings for us to find, and the Roman writers who describe druids watched from the far side of the fire with taxes and wars on their minds, their accounts colored by conquest. Centuries later, Irish and Welsh scribes copied old tales onto vellum in monastery lamplight, saving stories while changing their frames. A broken chain, honestly held.

What you hold instead is a working journal built from what survives, with every claim labeled so you always know the ground under your feet. Where old stones or manuscripts speak, you will hear them as Attested, the firmest ground. Where later folk custom likely carries an older shape, this book names it folk, a fair guess but not proof. Where modern hands fill the gaps with new rites, it says Modern or Reconstructed. You will find the label waiting at the foot of each lore page in its Lore Root, so doubt always has somewhere to sit.

Try this at your table tonight with a pen and ten unhurried minutes. Write one sentence for what you hope this book will give you, and one for what you hope it will leave out, then read both aloud to hear if they sound true. Keep that page marked for the whole year. When a later chapter puzzles or dazzles you, return to those two sentences and let them judge the chapter.

Lore Root: method statement for this book — Modern, built on attested sources throughout.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *In your own words, give me one sentence for what you hope this book will give you, and one sentence for what you hope it will leave out.*

THRESHOLD

The Three Realms blessing

An old Irish oath runs on three legs, and you can still feel its balance today. In medieval Irish tales the Dagda himself, the good god and father among the Irish gods, swears by Land and Sea and Sky together as his witnesses, staking his word on the whole world holding. Later folk prayers keep naming the same trio over hearth and sickbed, blessing and warding with three. The oath wording is Attested in medieval sources; the wide daily use made of it here is Reconstructed. Three witnesses round one fire.

Treat the three as a plain daily check-in rather than high doctrine. Land is your body and home, everything you can touch and sweep and mend. Sea is the feeling underneath, what moves and dreams and worries in the night. Sky is vision and direction, the wider weather you share with gods and neighbors. When one realm runs loud and another goes quiet, you know where to put your hands next. Three old witnesses, three rooms of one small life.

Stand or sit where you are and try the three-breath blessing, which takes under a minute. Breathe into your feet for land, your belly for sea, your brow for sky, and say quietly, Power of land, sea, and sky with me. Do it at waking or at the sink before dishes. If held breath ever strains you, speak the words low over tea instead. Small, bodily, repeatable — that is the point.

Lore Root: Land/Sea/Sky oath formula in Irish sources — Attested; three-breath practice — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Check in with yourself today and tell me which realm feels loudest in you, and which one has gone quiet.*

THRESHOLD

Which realm is loud right now? Name it and say what it wants.

THRESHOLD

Which realm is quiet — the one you may be neglecting? What does it need?

Noticing log, day one. Walk your watching spot. Date it. Three things seen, three heard.

Noticing log, day two. Same spot, same three-and-three. What changed since yesterday?

Entry vow, day three. What will you keep in this book for one full turning of the year?

Next door, not upstairs

Forget ladders and trapdoors when you picture the Otherworld, because the Irish and Welsh tales set it sideways to this one, like a country next door. The Irish manuscripts name its addresses plainly: Tir na nOg, the land of youth, and Mag Mell, the pleasant plain with its undying feast, and Tech Duinn, the house of Donn where the dead gather beyond the wave. The Welsh tales call it Annwn, the deep place, reached through mist and lake and mound. Near, not above.

Read those addresses as story-truth rather than travel directions, and keep the layers straight. That the tales name these islands and halls is Attested in medieval manuscripts — firm ground. That country folk later spoke of fairy hills and night visitors belongs to folk custom, a likely echo but not the same voice. That you might map it onto your own dreams or streets is Modern, your honest overlay, true to you but not evidence for them. Same door, three keys.

Give it twenty minutes at your table with paper and a pencil. Sketch your own life as a house with one extra door: mark where that door stands, what lies one step beyond it in three small details — a smell, a sound, a light — and who you would trust to knock first. Keep the drawing plain and label it with today's date. You are learning the neighborhood before you visit.

Lore Root: Otherworld islands and halls across Irish and Welsh tales — Attested in medieval manuscripts.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Picture a country sitting just next door to your own life, and describe it in three small details.*

OTHERWORLD

Pwyll trades places

Take the First Branch of the Mabinogi, the great medieval Welsh story collection, and open on Pwyll, a young prince out hunting who offends Arawn, a king of Annwn. To mend it he trades places and shapes with Arawn for a full year, ruling the deep kingdom justly, sleeping chastely beside a strange queen with his back turned each night, and meeting Arawn's enemy in single combat at the ford. He comes home with honor and a lifelong friend. A year of borrowed kingship, cleanly kept.

Hear the tale as a lesson in held boundaries rather than a model for worship. That Pwyll and Arawn trade kingdoms is Attested as medieval Welsh story, not history and not ritual instruction. Nobody converts and nobody conquers here; two kings simply keep each other's houses well for a season, and both peoples prosper for it. Folk and Modern retellings sometimes moralize it further into parable — leave those aside and let the old shape stand on its own feet.

Sit down for half an hour and borrow the prince's audit for your own rooms. Write what kingdom you would be trusted to keep for a year — a flat, a friendship, a workbench — and list three things you would tend, one you would refuse to touch, and the promise you would keep to the letter. Sign it lightly in pencil and revisit it at month's end. Borrowed things teach careful hands.

Lore Root: Pwyll and Arawn in the First Branch of the Mabinogi — Attested medieval Welsh tale.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *If you were given a whole year to keep someone else's kingdom, how would you spend it?*

How the door opens

The doors keep habits, and once you learn them you start seeing them everywhere in the tales. Burial mounds stand open at Samhain while boats sail west to the islands, mists settle low on hillsides, and a hunter follows a white stag with red ears — the tales' own signal-fires — straight into a court he never looked for. Water and hill and mist and feast-night return again and again across Irish and Welsh stories, always at the seam. Edges, not centers.

Treat that pattern as literary rather than literal, and keep it distinct from later habit. That mounds and mists and white animals mark entries is Attested as a tale-pattern across the manuscripts. That country people still leave certain hills and wells alone belongs to folk custom, suggestive but separate. Your own sense that some streets change at dusk is Modern experience, true to you but no evidence for them. Pattern, echo, life — three different weights.

Give ten minutes to a walk around your own block with soft eyes and a small notebook. Mark three spots where the air seems to change — a stairwell with its own weather, a tree with traffic of its own, a corner gone quieter — and write one line for each about what shifted. No rite and no offering, attention only. When you get home, read the three lines aloud and circle the one that pulls hardest; that is your thin place for the month.

Lore Root: liminal entries across Irish and Welsh tales — Attested as literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Think of your own town and tell me where the air changes for you, and name that spot plainly.*

The rules of visiting

Guests survive the Otherworld on manners, and the tales repeat the house rules so often you can recite them by heart. Eat little or eat knowingly, take nothing without leave, keep your promise to the letter, and never mistake the host's courtesy for your own power. Pwyll keeps every rule and prospers, while boasters and thieves in tale after tale pay exactly the price they were told at the door. Old hospitality, hard edges.

Use those rules as household sense first and story scholarship second. That guest-rules run through the tales is Attested as literary pattern, not a code anyone carved in stone. Folk custom keeps a cousin-shape in gifts left at wells and thresholds to stay on good terms — related, not identical. Modern use here simply turns the mirror around: imagine yourself the host and ask what your own rooms require of strangers. The card on your cupboard is the modern half, and honesty keeps it clean. Tale, custom, table.

Tonight write the three rules you would post on your own door, as if a prince might come to read them. Keep them short enough to fit an index card, plain enough for a tired guest, and kind enough that you would keep them yourself. Tape the card inside a cupboard and live with it a week. If a rule fails by day three, rewrite it shorter instead of scolding yourself; house rules are drafts, and drafts improve.

Lore Root: guest-rules across the tales — Attested as literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *List the three rules you would post on your own door for visitors to your kingdom.*

The veil walk

Start with the doorway you already cross every day, because the old pattern says thresholds listen. Stand in yours and breathe three slow breaths while you name land and sea and sky, then walk ten minutes with soft eyes and empty hands, listening more than looking, and notice everything that feels sideways — a colder step, a bird going quiet, a smell with no source. Walk home the same way and close with a word of thanks. Dawn or dusk sharpens it, when light itself stands between.

Hold this walk for what it is and no more. Doorway and twilight liminality grows from tale-patterns and folk custom, so this book labels the whole exercise Reconstructed practice — an honest modern making, not an old rite handed down. It borrows the tales' love of edges the way you borrow a neighbor's ladder: with thanks, and returned unharmed. What it gives back is steadier notice, not messages. No trance, no summons, nothing bound or commanded.

Choose your time now, dawn or dusk, and your doorway, front or back or stairwell. Set ten minutes by the kitchen timer, leave the phone home, and carry nothing but keys and attention. If weather pins you indoors, walk the hallway instead and note its doors; edges live inside too. When you return, give the walk four lines in this book: where you went, what turned sideways, what stayed ordinary.

Lore Root: doorway and twilight liminality from tale-patterns and folk custom — Reconstructed practice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Choose your time and place, and tell me whether you will walk at dawn or dusk, and which doorway you will use.*

Dawn and dusk primer

Half-light carries half the stories, and your own street can show you why. The tales love edges where one thing becomes another: bargains struck at fords between banks, meetings at doorways between rooms, messages arriving in the minute between sleeping and waking, all lit by a low sun or a single candle. Folk custom still honors the seams, keeping dawn water drawn before sunrise and dusk candles lit against the dark in living memory. Neither-times, kept daily.

Separate the layers and both stay useful. That twilight edges fill the tales is Attested as literary motif, and that country households kept dawn and dusk observances belongs to folk custom — suggestive continuities, not proof of one old rite. Sitting five minutes to watch the sky change needs no lineage at all; call it Modern rest, plain and unborrowed, the kind any tired person may keep. Old motif, old habit, present rest.

Pick dawn or dusk and keep it three days running, five minutes each, wherever you can see sky from your flat — window, step, balcony, even a cracked-open door. Keep the same seat each day so change shows. No phone and no rite, just watching while the light does its work and your shoulders drop. Afterward write three lines: what the light did, what sounds came and went, what shifted inside you. Three small sittings make a hinge you can feel swing.

Lore Root: twilight edges in tale and folk custom — Folk survival and literary motif.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *For the next three days, say whether dawn or dusk will be yours, and why you chose it.*

Dreaming across

Night hands you the cheapest boat to the other shore, and the tales treat it as traffic rather than trivia. Across the Irish and Welsh manuscripts warnings arrive in dreams, lovers visit sleeping chambers, and the dead speak plainly before dawn, their words steering battles and marriages alike. Whether or not you credit any of that yet, the storytellers took night messages seriously, and wrote them down as counsel. Dreams carried weight.

Keep the old claim and the new habit apart and both stay honest. That dream-visits fill the tales is Attested as literary motif, not proof the old parties kept dream books. Folk dictionaries of dream-meanings are later make, and this book sets them aside entirely. The seven-night log offered here is Modern practice, useful because dates and images show your own weather, not because symbols decode. Your dates, your hand. Motif old, notebook new.

Set this book beside your bed tonight with a pen that writes in the dark, tied to the cover with string so midnight you can find it. When you wake, catch one image before your feet touch the floor — a color, a creature, a sentence — and give it three lines with the date, every night dated even when blank. No dictionaries and no decoding, seven nights running. Patterns matter more than interpretations, and your hand will learn the oar-stroke.

Lore Root: dream-visits across the tales — Attested as literary motif; dream-logging — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Set this book by your bed tonight, then recount last night's dream in three lines.*

Thin-place map: sketch your town in words. Mark three spots where the air changes.

Dream log, night one. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night two. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night three. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night four. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night five. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night six. Date. One image, three lines.

Dream log, night seven. Date. One image, three lines. Then read all seven.

Otherworld neighbor page: what single rule would you keep there, and what would it cost?

Keep the cultures separate

Picture three neighboring houses on one lane, related but never the same household, each with its own door and its own manners. In the Gaulish house the gods reach you as short prayers cut in stone, little votive inscriptions set up by soldiers and merchants and townsfolk, with a carved image here and there and almost no story attached. In the Irish and Welsh houses it runs the other way entirely, with rich tales copied by Christian scribes centuries after conversion, full of speech and quarrel and marvel, but thin on altars and offerings. Two kinds of evidence, neither wrong.

Read each house on its own terms and the confusion that fills so many books lifts like mist. More than four hundred local Celtic divine names survive in inscriptions, yet only a handful were ever widely shared, so any page that flattens them into one pantheon is selling you something modern and tidy. Attested stone names belong to Gaul, while the big personalities belong to medieval Irish and Welsh literature, and the bridge between the two is Reconstructed at best. This chapter keeps the doors marked on purpose, Gaulish-named ones first, then Irish, then Welsh, each greeted in their own way and never blended at the table.

Try it tonight at the kitchen table in twenty minutes with a pencil and this book open flat. Walk the chapter in order, door by door, and jot which one pulls you and why in a single honest line. Greet that household first and let the other two wait their turn, the way you would with new neighbors. One open door teaches more than three half-opened ones, and the household you enter properly will lend you its calm and its customs for the rest of the year.

Lore Root: 400+ local names in inscriptions vs. a few pan-regional figures — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Of these three doors, Gaul, Ireland, and Wales, tell me which one you will open first and what draws you to it.*

Cernunnos, the horned one

On the Gundestrup cauldron, a great decorated silver vessel found in Denmark, he sits cross-legged and antlered, holding a neck-ring in one hand, ringed round by stag and bull and lion. The antlers rise like bare winter branches above a calm human face, and the beasts press close as if posing for a portrait nobody commissioned. Scholars debate the vessel's makers, but the image itself is plain to anyone who looks. On the Pillar of the Boatmen at Paris his name is carved in stone by river-merchants doing business under Rome, plain letters beside carved gods, a businessman's devotion. No tale tells what he says or wants, and that silence is nearly the whole of him.

Treat that silence as the teaching rather than a gap to fill with invention. He reads as wild plenty that never negotiates and cannot be owned, the deer path and the weed lot going on without you whether you praise it or not. Later stories casting him as a horned god of witches are modern make, worth leaving out here, because the Attested part fits in two objects and the rest is wishful stitching. Two witnesses, one image and one inscription, carry more weight than a shelf of speculation, and this book trusts the two witnesses.

Honor him with attention rather than requests, close to home and often through the year. Stand a full minute where trees and weeds do as they please, a park corner or a cracked pavement bed, name what lives there, carry some litter home in your pocket. Watching can be worship when it is repeated weekly in all weathers, and ten kept minutes at the same spot count for more than an altar you never visit. Go in rain too; the wild does not close for weather, and neither should the watcher.

Lore Root: Gundestrup image plus Pillar of the Boatmen inscription — Attested; all stories about him — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Picture some stretch of wild plenty that answers to no one, and say in one line what it means to you.*

Cernunnos — practice

Pick one watching spot you can reach on foot, somewhere half-wild is allowed to go on being itself without tidying. A canal bank, a churchyard corner, the unmown strip behind the flats, anywhere with weeds and birds and insects living unconsulted by committees. Go there at the same hour twice in one week and stand still long enough for the place to forget you are there. Learn its regulars by sight before you offer anything at all, the way you would learn neighbors' faces before knocking.

The offering here is manners, not transaction, and that distinction carries the whole rite from start to finish. Pouring a little clean water to the roots, keeping one path clear of rubbish, carrying litter home, naming three wild neighbors aloud, these are Reconstructed gestures built on the old pattern of care at shrines. Nothing is asked for and nothing is bargained, because the wild plenty this god images does not negotiate and would not understand the question. You are a guest showing good manners, nothing grander, and that is enough.

Keep the whole round under half an hour, phone away and hands free and eyes up. Name bird and weed and insect by whatever honest names you have, garden-book or made-up-but-kept, and write them in this book when you get home with the date beside each line. Take every trace of the visit out with you, down to the last crumb and tissue, and let the returning itself become the vow you keep.

Lore Root: outdoor offering manners — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Standing at your watching spot, name three wild neighbors and jot one small kindness you will do for each.*

Epona of the horses

Soldiers carried her name across the map, from Britain to Bulgaria, cut in stone wherever cavalrymen served far from home. Epona is a Gaulish horse-goddess, and her dedications rank among the best-attested Celtic cults anywhere in bronze and stone, set up by riders who depended on their animals daily for life itself. Picture a tired trooper in a strange province paying a carver for her image, wanting his mare watched over through the winter campaign. She guards horses and riders, travelers and stables alike, steady and unsentimental, asking clean straw rather than poetry.

Almost no stories of her survive, so her worship reads best as stable manners rather than mythology, and that is a relief rather than a lack. Care of working animals, care of the road, care of fellow travelers, that is the household shape of her, and it fits any century with hooves or wheels in it. Attested dedications give you the whom and where; the how is Reconstructed from the life around horses, and it always comes down to hands doing the work instead of mouths making promises. Grooming beats hymns every time.

Translate that into your own week without needing a horse of your own or a stable. Groom something that works hard, your bicycle or your boots or an old dog, walk one errand you would normally ride, feed the working animals first before you sit down to eat. She reads hands better than altars, and a brushed coat or a mended strap says the prayer for you more plainly than any verse you could memorize.

Lore Root: dedications across the Roman world — Attested; stories — none survive.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Who does the carrying in your life? Name the human or animal bearer you most depend on.*

Epona — practice

Start with the road you actually travel, not an imagined Roman highway with cypresses. Her old gifts were simple things left where horses and travelers pass, milk or water, bread or apples, and the gift still matters less than the work beside it. Check a bridle, pick a hoof, oil a chain, pump a tire, carry a traveler's bag one stop further than comfort suggests. Let your hands learn the shape of the work before your mouth describes it.

Make the kindness specific and road-shaped, because vague goodwill evaporates by Tuesday and helps nobody at all. Drive gently past riders, yield to the horse-box on narrow lanes, refill the water bowl at the stable gate, sweep the shared entry where wheels jam every morning. Each small road-kindness belongs to her pattern, Reconstructed but honest, work-as-offering rather than words-as-offering, and the street notices even when no one thanks you. Especially then.

Close the loop in this book within the week, under an hour all told including the errand itself. Write what you gave, where you left it, and what your hands did besides the giving, with a date beside each line for the record. The record matters more than the poetry here, since her old worship survives in ledgers of care rather than in hymns, and ledgers want dates and details. Ride or walk the same road again next week, and add a second line beneath the first.

Lore Root: work-as-offering — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *For this week, spell out the road-work that is yours and name whose bag you will carry.*

Taranis of the wheel

Lucan, a Roman poet writing about Gaul, names Taranis among the gods of the Gauls, and stones across the old provinces carve him beside his wheel. The wheel reads as sun and thunder and turning year all at once, spokes holding the sky's motion in one round sign you can trace with a finger on the page. Wherever Romans met him they paired him with Jupiter, their own sky-father, which tells you how seriously the sky was taken by everyone laboring under it. Thunder was never decoration; it was the roof of the world talking.

Thunder gods ask for upright conduct more than for poetry, and that is the household meaning to carry home from this page. Keep oaths, pay debts, offer shelter when storms come, stand straight while the sky is loud and do not use the noise as cover for crookedness. The Attested part is the name and the wheel and the Roman pairing; the character notes are Reconstructed, drawn from what thunder has always demanded of people huddled beneath it. Straight dealing is the oldest lightning rod.

Picture the next storm as his audit rather than his anger, a yearly review arriving early and unannounced. Step under solid cover, listen it through to the end without fidgeting, review one promise you made and whether it still holds water. No drama is needed, only exactness, because thunder hears everything and forgets nothing, and the review ends when the rain does.

Lore Root: Lucan plus wheel-inscriptions — Attested; character notes — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Ask yourself which oath of yours needs thunder behind it, and say what it is.*

Taranis — practice

Thunder gives you the timetable, so let the next storm call the rite instead of your calendar. Step out once under solid cover, balcony or porch or open window, and listen the whole weather through if you can do it safely, rain on the sill and gutters talking over the wind. Speak one oath aloud, short enough to keep without footnotes or escape clauses, and let the rain witness it instead of any person. The sky makes a fine witness because it cannot be flattered.

Keep the words plain and the ledger simpler still, because tangled vows rot first and everyone knows it. Pay one debt within the week, money or message or mended thing, and note what you swore and what you paid in two lines here with dates beside both. His pattern is oath-keeping as rite, Reconstructed but sturdy, and the whole account should fit on a scrap of paper kept folded in this book.

Mind the plain safety of it every single time without exception. Never stand in the open with metal, never chase the storm for effect, come inside promptly when lightning walks close. Ten minutes of listening, one sentence of vow, one debt settled, all inside the hour and mostly indoors. What you swore and what you paid, that is the whole religion of this page, and it balances cleanly. File the scrap in this book when the debt is paid, and let the balanced page witness for the next storm.

Lore Root: oath-keeping as rite — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *In plain words here, speak one oath short enough to keep and name the debt you will pay this week.*

Teutates, protector of the people

Toutatis in some inscriptions, Teutates in Lucan, the name itself means the god of the tribe, the people as one body rather than one hero on a horse. Lucan, the Roman poet who names the gods of Gaul, names him among them, and the dedications read like civic prayer for folk and town and borderland. Call on him when the trouble is shared and nobody's job in particular: the damp stairwell everyone ignores, the rota nobody covers, the street that floods every autumn while the council looks away.

His worship is neighbor-work, plain and regular, and it begins at your own front door rather than at some distant shrine. Learn your neighbors' names and use them, keep the shared path swept, show up for the unglamorous meeting where chairs outnumber speeches and the biscuits go stale by nine. Protection here is collective or it is nothing at all, and the Attested name-meaning backs that reading without needing any modern gloss or borrowed ceremony. The tribe is whoever shares your postcode.

Try him as a habit rather than a hymn, one small civic act each week without fail. One remembered name used aloud, one swept landing, one attended meeting a month, small change that compounds quietly like interest. Tribes run on records of care kept over years, and your street is tribe enough to start with tonight, exactly as it is and exactly as you are.

Lore Root: name-meaning plus Lucan plus inscriptions — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look down your own street and describe the shared trouble sitting on it.*

Teutates — practice

Bread and drink open this one, set out for the household with an extra portion for whoever passes by, walker or driver or delivery rider in the rain. Eat together if the hour allows, or wrap the spare portion and hand it over warm, because the warmth counts as part of the prayer and reheated kindness still feeds a cold person. Then do one piece of shared work before the day ends, while the bread is still fresh in memory and the goodwill is warm.

Choose the unglamorous job on purpose and do not announce it beforehand. The hallway, the verge, the bin area, the rota nobody wants to touch, whatever makes the place work for everyone. Do it properly instead of performatively, note who it served, and write that line here with a date, since tribes run on remembered kindness rather than announced kindness. The pattern is shared-work offering, Reconstructed from civic dedications, and the written record is half the rite itself.

Hold the whole round inside an hour, shopping included if you keep it simple and local. Flat bread and tap water qualify fully; no feast is required and no guest list either, and fanciness would miss the point. Keep that written record through the month, because remembered care holds a people together longer than any single generous day, and the pages quietly add up. Read the month's lines aloud at the end, and choose next month's shared work from what they show.

Lore Root: shared-work offering — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Name the shared work you will do this week, and say exactly who it will serve.*

Rosmerta and Sucellus

Across Gaul they stand together in stone, a working pair carved at shrine after shrine with the patience of people who paid the carver by the letter. Rosmerta, whose name means the bountiful one, carries her basket of plenty; Sucellus, the god of the mallet, shoulders his long-handled hammer, a tool that builds as much as it breaks. At some shrines Nantosuelta, another Gaulish provider-goddess, keeps the same company, because prosperity here wears work-clothes and aprons rather than crowns. Plenty with a hammer in its hand is the whole theology.

Their message reads plainly off the carvings for any household willing to look with practical eyes. Plenty follows order: tools cleaned, stores counted, something made, something shared, the workshop and the kitchen kept well enough to actually work in. The paired images and dedications are Attested across Gaul in stone; the household translation is yours to test, shelf by shelf, and your own pantry can prove or disprove it within a single month. The carvings make a claim you can check.

Look at what your rooms make with their hours this week and be specific rather than dreamy. One shelf counted, one tool cleaned and oiled, one thing mended before it is replaced, small liturgy with large and compounding effect. Generosity rides on top of order here, never instead of it, and the basket stays full where the mallet is respected, used, and put away clean.

Lore Root: paired images and dedications across Gaul — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Tell me plainly: what does your household make with its hands and its hours?*

Rosmerta and Sucellus — practice

Set aside the first and best of something you make, the first bread from the batch, the first row weeded, the first page drafted clean. Share part of it the same day it is finished, because plenty hoarded turns to lack in every story and generosity keeps the current moving between houses. The gift can be small; the promptness is the point, and warm matters more than large. Give it before you talk yourself into keeping the best bit.

Count your stores once this month in this book, tin by tin or jar by jar, since numbers are their liturgy and guesses are not worship. The pattern is first-fruits sharing, Reconstructed from festival shapes, fitted to a flat with a shelf and a stove rather than a farm with barns. What you track honestly tends to stretch further than what you only hope about, and the counting itself takes barely twenty minutes with a pencil.

Finish inside the hour: make, portion, deliver, count, all four steps before supper. Knock on one door, hand over the share warm, come home and log the making and the giving in two dated lines side by side. Repeat monthly and watch the shelf teach you what the carvings only hinted, that order feeds bounty and bounty feeds the street, round and round without end. Mark the next month's making-date in the margin now, so the round does not depend on remembering later.

Lore Root: first-fruits sharing — Reconstructed from festival pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *This month, what first thing will you make, and what first share will you give away?*

The Dagda, the good god

Tales call him the good god, meaning good at everything rather than merely good-hearted, and you meet him across the medieval Irish stories including Cath Maige Tuired, the tale of the battle of Mag Tuired. He carries a club that kills with one end and brings back to life with the other, owns a cauldron that leaves no company unfed, and plays a harp that orders the seasons into their places with music. Appetite and generosity share one huge body here, often within the same hour, and the scribes who copied him never tidy him up for company.

Take him as hospitality at scale, with the rough edges deliberately left in and visible. Feed everyone, grudge no portion, let the cauldron teach you there is enough, then notice where he is crude as well and learn that too, because flattery is not devotion and editing him is not respect. The tales are Attested as medieval Irish literature, not as a manual for behavior, so read the bigness as picture-language for a household virtue rather than as license for excess at the table.

Test the virtue at your own stove this week with one stretching pot that costs little. Cook enough for a guest you have not named yet, ladle first for whoever comes to the door, eat last yourself, and watch how the table changes shape around a full pot. Enormous need not mean expensive; it means ungrudging to the last spoonful, and a lentil pot can carry the cauldron-shape as honestly as any feast.

Lore Root: Cath Maige Tuired and related medieval Irish tales — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Be honest with yourself here: where are you generous, and where are you crude?*

The Dagda — practice

Cook once extra this week and share it hot, neighbor or coworker or stranger, bread or milk or ale or whatever the house already holds in store. Eat together if the hour allows; carry it over steaming if it does not, because the warmth counts as part of the offering and cold charity comforts less than hot. One fed table is the whole rite, and no speech or ceremony is required at any point in the evening.

Keep the hospitality pattern honest and small enough to repeat monthly without dread or expense. A single extra portion, a clean container you do not need back, a knock and a name and a minute of chat on the doorstep in the cold. The shape is Reconstructed from the tales' feasting, fitted to a flat kitchen with one oven and a tight budget, and repetition matters far more than scale or show. Plain food given often beats a feast given once.

Write who ate and what was said when you get home, since feasts are records and memory leaks by morning. Two lines, a date, one overheard sentence worth keeping for winter reading. Under an hour from chopping board to washing up for a simple pot, and the table you fed will remember longer than the pot you washed, which is exactly the point of the exercise. Keep the container if it comes back, wash it well, and use it again next month, so the giving grows its own standing round.

Lore Root: hospitality-offering — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Decide now: who will you feed this week, and what do you hope gets said at that table?*

The Morrigan, plainly

Ulster tales show her stark and leave her so, and this page follows their example without softening a line. The Morrigan, an Irish figure of battle and prophecy and kingship, offers herself to the hero Cu Chulainn and he refuses her, and she harries him toward his death thereafter without relenting or forgiving. She is also seen washing bloody armor at the ford before battle, a sight no warrior mistakes for anything but its one meaning. Read these scenes exactly as written, with no comfort added and none expected by the wise.

She is war's appetite and fate's messenger, never a mascot and never a mother to flatter into favors with sweet words. If she draws you, bring discipline and nothing else: show up, keep promises, face conflict directly, sort which battles are genuinely yours and abandon the rest without guilt. The Ulster and battle-texts are Attested; soft modern readings that gentle her into a protectoress belong elsewhere entirely, not on this page, which keeps its edge honed.

Let her question do its cold work on you tonight with pen in hand and the door shut. List your live conflicts, strike the ones that are only noise or other people's weather, keep the single one that is truly yours to fight. Clarity is the only devotion she respects, and one cleanly named battle outweighs a year of vague readiness and worry that helps nobody.

Lore Root: Ulster tales and battle-texts — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Sort it out in writing: which conflict is actually yours, and which is only noise?*

The Morrigan — practice

Name one hard honest thing and do it within three days: the message sent, the boundary held, the apology made without garnish or self-defense attached. No ritual dressing is needed and none is wanted; the difficult act itself is the offering, performed in daylight with witnesses. Record what it cost afterward in plain figures, time and money and pride, because courage leaves a receipt and vague bravery leaves nothing but a story told later.

Hold the line spare on purpose, since she accepts no substitutes and no delays dressed as preparation. One act, one date, one cost, witnessed by this book and no audience beyond its pages. The pattern is discipline-as-offering, Reconstructed from the tales' hard logic, and it fails the moment it is decorated or delayed or delegated to someone braver than you feel. Spare means spare: no candles, no speeches, just done.

Keep the aftermath clean as well, which is harder than the act itself and lasts longer. No retelling for applause, no punishment stacked on shame, only the mending logged and the thread resumed the next morning like work. Offer courage or offer nothing at all, and let the three-day window close behind you like a gate with a definite sound. Write the closing date beneath it, and begin the next morning with a clean page and no backward glances allowed, because the gate only opens forward.

Lore Root: discipline-as-offering — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Three days, one hard honest thing: name it and the day you will do it.*

Lugh of the many skills

Strangers at Tara, the old hill of kingship in Ireland, ask what one man can do, and Lugh answers everything: harpist and smith and poet and warrior all at once, each craft ready to be shown on demand. He earns his seat at the crowded door by mastery of every craft named, then leads the hosting at Mag Tuired, the great mythic battle told in Cath Maige Tuired. His assembly-festival carries his name each August at Lughnasadh, when skill is displayed and deals struck and contests run on the fair green before crowds.

Take the gift with its warning attached, because excellence curdles into pride fast and his own tales show the price plainly to anyone reading. Display the work, then share the credit; let the harvest feed everyone, not just your name on the prize list at the top. The Tara seat-taking and the battle leadership are Attested tale-patterns; the August fair-name is Attested too, and the moral for your household is plain and portable across centuries.

Ask your hands what they know that deserves daylight this season rather than another year in the drawer. One skill shown, one contest entered, one technique passed on before the season turns and the evenings close in early. The god of many crafts honors the craft you finish and share with others, not the ten you only describe at parties when the talk turns to what you might do.

Lore Root: Cath Maige Tuired plus Lughnasadh naming — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Think of your own hands: which skill of yours deserves a showing this season?*

Lugh — practice

Sharpen one skill in public this month, on purpose and on record where others can see the work. Enter the thing, the show or the market or the open-mic or the club ladder, and run the contest with yourself as much as with others, personal best first and prizes second. Then teach one technique to someone worse at it than you, slowly and without condescension, the way you once needed to be taught yourself. Teaching exposes what practice hides.

Taste the first fruit with its story told aloud to someone, the loaf or the song or the mended chair, and name who taught you and who you taught in turn. The pattern is craft-display as rite, Reconstructed from the Lughnasadh fair-shape of showing and trading, and improvement logged honestly is his incense. Log the contest and the lesson side by side here with dates, so the progress shows on paper even when it feels slow.

Fit it to an hour a week and guard that hour against all comers and excuses. Forty minutes of practice, twenty of teaching or showing, week after week without gaps. Small, repeated, witnessed, because a vow you keep in daylight beats a masterpiece nobody ever sees in a drawer. Bring the work, share the credit, and let the harvest table stretch a little wider than your own plate this year. Book the next showing-date before this one cools, so the craft stays in daylight all year round.

Lore Root: craft-display as rite — Reconstructed from Lughnasadh pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Name the contest you will enter and the technique you will teach, both in one place.*

Brigid, carefully

Say the name slowly, because three different women share it and you should never blur them into one convenient figure. The goddess of the old tales is an Irish goddess, a daughter of the Dagda, a poetess said to own two oxen, known from only a few thin fragments that fit on one page. The saint of Kildare, with her holy wells and tended flames and rush crosses, belongs to Christian tradition and later folk custom with centuries of devotion behind her and crowds still visiting. Joining the two into one timeless goddess is modern make, however fondly meant and beautifully written.

Name the one you mean before you begin, aloud and on paper, because honoring one and venerating the other and blending the two are three different acts with different addresses. Then pick her thread, poet or smith or healer, and work it daily for a month without switching when boredom strikes. The goddess fragments are Attested but thin; the saint's tradition is Attested as Christian and folk custom; the fusion is Modern, set aside here for honesty rather than hostility.

Hold the practice to one thread so the distinction stays visible in your hands and your diary. A dated line a day for the poet, one tool tended for the smith, one body cared for on schedule for the healer, rest counted as care too rather than laziness. Small daily work carries her fire better than one grand night of candles, and the dated lines will show which woman you actually walked with by month's end.

Lore Root: goddess fragments plus saint's tradition — Fragments attested; joining them — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Poet, smith, or healer: which thread is yours for this month, and why that one?*

Brigid — practice

Take the thread you named and let the practice fit it exactly, no borrowing from the other two when the week drags. Poets write one daily line and date it; smiths work one tool or skill with repetition until the edge holds and sings; healers give care on schedule, yours or another's, with rest counted as care too. One thread only, all month, no switching when the novelty fades in week two and the page stays blank.

Speak the work aloud in plain words when it is done, because plain speech is her prayer and flourish is not required. A dated line, a stropped blade, a kept appointment, each said out loud and logged here in one sentence with its date attached. The thread-practice is Reconstructed, built to keep the three women distinct while your hands learn one craft properly rather than three badly. Saying it aloud makes it real.

Keep it inside twenty minutes a day at the kitchen table, same hour if you can manage it. Pen and paper, whetstone and knife, calendar and kettle, whatever the thread requires and nothing more gathered or bought. Sum the month in a single line here when it ends, and you will know which Brigid you met by what your hands can do now that they could not do before. Date that last line twice, once for the thread and once for the woman, so the record shows which of the three you truly kept company with.

Lore Root: thread-practice — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Sum up your thread's daily practice for this month in a single line.*

Manannan of the sea

Mists and waves and a boat that needs no sail belong to him, and the old pages give him the whole horizon. Manannan is an Irish sea-lord you meet in Lebor Gabala, the medieval Irish Book of Invasions, and in the voyage-tales, veiling the ways between the worlds with weather and fog. He ferries and fosters and tests heroes as lord of the sea-roads and the islands beyond them, and what moves and changes and dreams and grieves belongs on his water by ancient right. Nothing adrift is outside his office.

Keep his meaning fluid on purpose, because the sea keeps what it is given without explaining itself or offering receipts to anyone. Watch the weather, learn your tides and rivers, pour water back to water, bring grief to the shore when words fail and let the tide do the talking for an hour. The voyage-tales are Attested as medieval literature; the comfort taken from them at a modern shoreline is Reconstructed, honest so long as it stays labeled and modest.

Find your nearest moving water this week, river or canal or tidal stair, and give it a full half-hour of your attention. Stand a while, note where it comes from and where it goes, say aloud what in your life feels at sea right now without editing. The sea-road does not fix the adrift thing; it carries it a little further along toward somewhere new, and that is help enough on some grey days.

Lore Root: Lebor Gabala and voyage-tales — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look at your own life and say what feels currently at sea, adrift or in motion.*

Manannan — practice

Fill a plain bowl at the tap and carry it to roots or river, and pour water back to water slowly with both hands like an offering that costs nothing. Walk one shore or towpath within the week, note one crossing where paths meet water, learn where your water comes from and where it goes after you, tap and river and rain all the way to the sea. Knowing the path is part of honoring it, and the walk with the pouring fits inside an hour door to door at an easy pace.

Keep the rite clean in both senses, inner intention and outer riverbank. Outdoors, pour nothing but water and milk, since the sea refuses plastic and the river refuses oil and the park refuses string and foil. The water-offering is Reconstructed from the old votive pattern of gifts at shores, shrunk to a flat-dweller's scale, and leave-no-trace is half of it rather than an afterthought. Carry out everything you carried in.

Log the pouring here in three lines: source, path, mouth, each with its date beside it. One bowl, one walk, one traced watershed, dated and done and witnessed by this book alone. Bring grief along if grief is what is moving in you; the sea-lord's oldest office is ferrying what cannot walk, and your poured bowl can carry its small share downstream with the rest. Walk the same shore again next month, and compare the waters like an old acquaintance worth revisiting.

Lore Root: water-offering — Reconstructed from votive pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Trace it in words: where does your water come from, and where does it go after you?*

Rhiannon of birds and horses

Riders in the First Branch of the Mabinogi, the great medieval Welsh story-collection, cannot catch her, though she never once gallops or hurries. Rhiannon comes on a white horse at a gentle pace, folding distance like cloth, and marries Pwyll, the same Pwyll who kept Arawn's kingdom faithfully for a year in another's shape. Later, wrongly blamed for a loss she did not cause, she carries travelers on her back as penance outside the gate. Her birds sing so sweetly they wake the dead and lull the living to sleep, and their song crosses worlds.

Let her stand alone and the story stays strong enough to hold you without props. Later readers sometimes braid her with Epona, the Gaulish horse-goddess, or with Macha of Ireland, but the tales say no such thing, and this book cuts the braid cleanly and keeps the cut visible. The Mabinogi Branches are Attested; the blending is Modern, and each lady keeps her own stable here with her own feed and tack and temper.

Hear her as endurance with courtesy kept inside it like a folded letter carried for years. Wronged and set to carrying, she carries well, without bitterness and without surrender, greeting each rider civilly at the gate. That bearing is the household teaching for hard weeks, and it asks nothing stranger of you than patience made useful when blame lands wrong and there is no appeal.

Lore Root: First and Third Branches of the Mabinogi — Attested; Epona-blending — Modern, cut here.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Remember a time you were wrongly blamed: what did you carry, and how did you carry it?*

Rhiannon — practice

Carry something for someone this week, the bag or the errand or the unglamorous lift across town, and do it the way she carried, steadily and without commentary or sighing. Patient endurance made useful is the whole offering; no one needs to know its name or its source in this book. One carried thing, one relieved back, one quiet mile without a sigh or a status update. Let the act stay small and complete.

Pair the carrying with listening, because her birds are half the story and silence is the other half that frames them. Hear birdsong once daily for a week, window open or street paused mid-stride, and log what you heard in a dated line with the place. The carrying-and-listening is Reconstructed, fitted to a flat and a commute, and attention counts as a kind of carrying too when it is given fully and not divided.

Record both side by side here when the week ends, under an hour all told for the writing and remembering. What you bore, for whom, and what sang while you bore it, two columns and seven lines with no garnish or moral attached. The penance-shape turns out to be a kindness-shape after all, and the birds keep the minutes better than any clock you own. Read the fortnight of lines aloud when the week ends, and let the smallness of the acts sit beside the steadiness of the song that ran through every one of them.

Lore Root: carrying-and-listening — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *This week, say what you will carry for someone and which birdsong you will log.*

Arawn of Annwn

Deep under the story stands a grey king who keeps his word even when it costs him dearly. Arawn is a Welsh king, lord of Annwn, the Welsh deep place, and you meet him in the First Branch of the Mabinogi riding out with his white hounds. He trades kingdoms with Pwyll for a full year and wins a lifelong friend, because Pwyll rules justly in his place, sleeping chastely, judging fairly, fighting faithfully at the ford. The year ends with gifts and gratitude on both sides, which is rarer in tales than it should be.

Arawn himself fights his own enemy at the appointed ford, keeps his bargain to the letter without trimming the edges, and parts with gifts and gratitude instead of suspicion. That kept bargain is the whole teaching: promise little, hold it exactly, fight only the named enemy, thank the stand-in warmly and by name. The First Branch is Attested; every oath-page in this book descends from his example in a Reconstructed line drawn carefully from Wales to your table.

Measure one of your own bargains against his this week with a pencil and no flinching. Which promise is loose, which enemy unnamed, which thanks unsaid since spring and now overdue. Tighten one, name one, speak one aloud, and feel the old story pull your modern word straight as a seam pressed flat. Your word can carry the same weight his did, if you keep it the same way he did.

Lore Root: First Branch of the Mabinogi — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Turn to your own bargains: which one of them needs exact keeping right now?*

Arawn — practice

Write one small vow for seven days in exact words, small enough to hold on your worst day of the week. The bed made before breakfast, the walk taken whatever the weather, the message answered before supper, whatever fits in one breath and survives a bad week intact. Keep it to the letter, neither adding nor trimming as the days pass, because plain records tell the truth and edited ones quietly lie. Small and exact beats large and approximate.

Log each kept day here without garnish, a tick and a date, no excuses and no essays about why Tuesday slipped away. Seven kept days beat seventy intended ones, and the vow-keeping is Reconstructed from Arawn's tale-shape into a flat-dweller's ordinary week. If it breaks, note the day honestly and resume the next morning without drama; the record, not perfection, is the rite you are learning.

Close the week with thanks in the Arawn manner, which is part of the bargain and not optional trim. Name who stood in for you, what held firm, what slipped, and speak one line of gratitude aloud to a person rather than the ceiling. Ten minutes a day, pen and paper, your own word as the deep place you visit. That is Annwn fitted to a diary, and it works quietly year after year. Begin the next seven days the morning after, with a fresh vow or the same one kept again, and let the chain lengthen.

Lore Root: vow-keeping — Reconstructed.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Here and now, choose your seven-day vow and write it down in exact words.*

Cerridwen, one page only

Little is told of her, and this book keeps it little on purpose rather than padding her out with borrowed robes. Cerridwen brews inspiration in her cauldron in the late Tale of Taliesin, a late Welsh tale, stirring a year-long brew meant for her own kin and no one else. She pursues the boy who steals three drops through many shapes, woman and hare and hen and grain chasing each other across the fields, until the drops work in him instead of her son. That chase is nearly the whole of her old story, powerful but small, a fragment rather than a cult with temples.

Give her one page and one use, the brewed thing, and treat wider goddess-cult claims about her as modern make, however beautifully written and sincerely meant. The Tale fragment is Attested but tiny; everything lifting her into a timeless great goddess is Modern, honestly labeled and set aside here without scorn or mockery. Smallness is not dismissal; it is accuracy, and accuracy is a kind of respect the old pages deserve from new readers.

Keep one slow project on the fire all month, a stew or a study or a draft, stirred on schedule and tasted honestly at set days you mark. Slow heat changes everything it touches, thickening and darkening by degrees you only notice when looking back across weeks. That brewed change is her true shape: one pot, one page, one patient month, no more claimed than the tale allows and no less than it offers.

Lore Root: Tale of Taliesin fragment — Attested but tiny; goddess-cult claims — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *What slow thing is brewing on your fire, and on which day will you taste it?*

Your altar page

One shelf can hold the whole chapter if you set it honestly and dust it weekly. A single cloth in a color you like, one candle in a safe holder that will not tip, water in a bowl changed often, one thing of the land, a stone or a feather or a cut stem from a walk. Add the names you honor said aloud rather than mumbled, and the shelf becomes a room. Face whatever matters from your window: sunrise east, the nearest hill, or the tree that outlasts the traffic below.

Tend it weekly the way you would a small animal, with food and cleaning and steady attention. Dusting, fresh water, one fresh stem, five minutes with your hands and none with your phone to distract you. Add a god's token only after a month of working with them, never before, and remove what goes stale without guilt or eulogy. The household shrine pattern is Reconstructed from shrine and well evidence, and relationship outranks display in every line of it. A tended shelf beats a crowded one.

Try the halving test tonight with a pencil before you buy or gather anything new. Describe your altar in words, then ask what would leave if the space halved, and then what would leave if it halved again to almost nothing. What survives two halvings is your true altar; set that much and no more, and it will hold every god in this book without crowding or dust.

Lore Root: household shrine pattern — Reconstructed from shrine and well evidence.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Describe your altar in words, then answer: if the space halved, what would leave?*

Who will you work with this year — and who will you respectfully not? Name both, with reasons.

Offering log: what did you give, to whom, and what came back?

- ☐ Water / milk / bread / song / work — date each
- ☐ To whom — name the figure
- ☐ What you asked, in one line
- ☐ What you offered back
- ☐ Leave-no-trace check (carried out?)
- ☐ Week two offering
- ☐ Week three offering
- ☐ Week four offering

Reread this chapter's twelve doors. Which figure stays with you past this month, and why?

Cu Chulainn takes arms

Seventeen, overhearing, choosing, the whole life decided in a single afternoon at Emain. Cu Chulainn is the great warrior of Ulster in the medieval Irish tales, and at seventeen he hears that whoever takes arms on a certain day will be famous but short-lived. He takes them anyway, glory with open eyes and no illusions about the price, and the Ulster tales then show him holding a ford alone against armies, war-frenzy and courtesy bound together in one young body. The druid's prophecy is overheard sideways, half by luck, and he acts on it within the hour.

His engine is the geis, a binding vow-taboo in the Irish tales that grants power exactly as long as it is kept and not a day longer. Two bind him hardest, never eat dog meat and never refuse hospitality, and when he is tricked into breaking both at once on a lonely road his death follows as the pattern demands. Read that shape as Attested literary pattern across the Ulster tales, and its household moral as plain: power with conditions, kept until it costs everything you have and then some.

Turn the tale on your own choices tonight with dates attached rather than vague memories. Name one road you took knowing its price, or one you refused for the same reason, and write the cost beside it in plain figures. No ford or frenzy is required of you; the choosing-with-open-eyes is the part that transfers across centuries intact. Glory aside, the question is whether you knew at the time, and whether knowing changed your grip on the weapon you chose.

Lore Root: Ulster Cycle, including the Tain — Attested medieval Irish tales.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *If you knew a choice would cost you years, would you still make it, and what would it be?*

The ford alone

Rivers make their own law, and the ford is neither bank but a narrow middle where armies must queue. At the ford they queue and he meets them one by one, because single combat at boundaries is the old pattern for settling what crowds cannot settle. There Cu Chulainn kills his foster-brother Ferdia, fellow pupil and beloved friend from their training days, weeping openly as he does it, and the grief does not stop the spear for a moment. The Tain, the great cattle-raid epic of the medieval Irish Ulster tales, shows him grieving exactly as much as he triumphs, page for grieving page.

Notice the restraint inside the frenzy, because that contrast is the teaching and the entire point of him. Challenges are issued properly, truces honored to the hour, the enemy praised by name before the fight begins, rage given manners like a hawk with jesses on. The single-combat-at-ford pattern is Attested as literary shape, not as history, and its household moral is that even necessary fighting keeps its form and its hours and its courtesies. Form is what separates battle from brawl.

Name your own narrow place between banks, the queue you meet one by one each working day. One inbox, one sickroom rota, one examination season, whatever funnels the world to single file at your door and will not be hurried. Hold it the ford way: properly, grievingly, without spilling the fight past its banks onto bystanders who never enlisted. That is the hero's part that fits inside a flat, and it is enough for any life.

Lore Root: single-combat-at-ford pattern in the Tain — Attested as literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Name the ford you are holding alone right now, the narrow place between banks.*

Fionn tastes wisdom

Burned thumb, sucked wisdom, lasting leadership held for decades afterward. Fionn leads the Fianna, the roving hunter-band of the medieval Irish Fenian tales, and burns his thumb on the Salmon of Knowledge, the fish of wisdom in those tales, snatching his hand back from the fire too late. He sucks the thumb ever after for counsel whenever judgment is needed, so his wisdom arrives by accident and stays by habit, consulted like an old scar that aches before rain and is never wrong about weather.

He leads through tests of poetry as much as arms, since no warrior joins who cannot compose verse on the spot and run the woods without rest or complaint, and he rations his marvels carefully where Cu Chulainn spends his freely. The Fenian tales are Attested medieval Irish tradition; the household reading is Reconstructed but fair: the cooler fire lasts longest, the leader listens first, counsel is sought before it is needed rather than after the mistake. Simmering carries further than blazing.

Try the thumb-trick in plain form this week at your own table with real questions. When a decision presses, pause a full minute, touch thumb to tooth in memory if you like, and ask what old accident already taught you about exactly this. Write the counsel down before acting, three dated lines in this book, then act on what you wrote. Simmering beats burning on most domestic days, and the scar knows things the mind forgot.

Lore Root: Fenian tales — Attested medieval Irish tradition.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Think back to some wisdom you got by accident: what was it, and do you use it?*

The hunter-band

Between households they live, by hunting and fighting and composing in turn through the seasons. The Fianna, the roving hunter-band of the Fenian tales, answer to no king and are judged by all, sleeping under the stars in summer and begging shelter at doors in winter. Their enlistment tests mix body and mind without apology: leaping and running and making a poem on the spot before witnesses who laugh at failure. A hero here must answer in verse as well as in blows, or go home to his mother's house and stay there.

Borrow the pairing, not the wandering, because the shape fits a flat week neatly without needing a forest or a king. One physical practice and one made thing, weekly, run and write, walk and carve, lift and sing, your choice of honest pair. The Fianna tests are Attested as literary pattern; your weekly version is Modern, openly so, and the pairing keeps both sides honest when one would rather loaf and the other would rather dream. Body and making correct each other.

Set the test tonight in two lines with days attached and no wiggle room. Which practice of body, which act of making, and on which evenings they live through the week. Keep each under an hour, pen and shoes by the door ready to grab, and review monthly whether both still live or one has quietly died. The band you join is yourself at two trades, and that small enlistment holds all year if you muster weekly.

Lore Root: Fianna tests — Attested as literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Set your own enlistment test: which practice of body and which act of making will you keep weekly?*

Boudica answers

History, not marvel, carries this page from first line to last without relief. Boudica was the historical queen of the Iceni, a people in Britain, and you know her from the Roman histories of Tacitus and Dio, enemies who admired her even as they condemned her cause. Wronged by Rome in her own house and person beyond bearing, she raised a revolt that burned three cities before it fell, and no gods walk in this story, no magic bends it, only a real woman and a real grievance and a real cost counted in ashes and graves. The ground remembers even when the winners write.

Keep her here as ballast against fantasy, because sometimes the Otherworld never shows up and courage has to do without it entirely. The Roman accounts are Attested as historical sources, hostile but real, and the household moral needs no marvel to stand upright: stand up anyway, count the cost honestly beforehand, pay it knowing and do not send the bill to others. Unassisted courage is still courage, and the page honors it as such.

Ask your nerve for one unassisted act this month, chosen and dated here in ink. No charm, no omen, only preparation and timing and follow-through, logged in plain lines with the outcome whatever it is. Yours can do without magic too, and the page will hold the ash and the account alike without flinching or looking away.

Lore Root: Roman histories (Tacitus, Dio) — Attested historical figure.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *When did you act with no magic helping, only your own nerve? Tell that story briefly.*

Vercingetorix holds out

Caesar's pages name him, and later histories carry the name onward with respect he never lived to see. Vercingetorix was the historical Gaulish leader who united the Gauls against Caesar city by city at last, held Alesia against siege when the walls closed in and hunger did its work, and surrendered himself to spare his people, dying afterward a prisoner in Rome. Strategy and unity arrived too late, the bill was presented in full, and no marvel softens any line of the account. Read it slowly; it does not improve with speed.

Pair him with Boudica and read the pair as one lesson across the Channel, because unity in time matters more than courage alone in any age. Separate cantons, separate kings, one siege too many, the pattern repeats wherever households split their strength and meet the crisis separately instead of together. The histories are Attested; the household scaling is yours to draw, and your table is smaller than Gaul but the arithmetic holds exactly the same.

Name the alliance of yours that is coming too late, and what single act would hurry it along this week. One phone call, one shared calendar, one mended quarrel before the siege closes and the options narrow to none. Small unity in time beats great unity afterward, and this page asks only for the hurrying, not the heroics or the speeches.

Lore Root: Caesar and later histories — Attested historical figure.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Which alliance of yours is coming too late, and what would hurry it along?*

Your geis, explained

Heroes in the Irish tales live inside spoken rules the way fish live in water, never questioning the element. A geis is a binding vow-taboo, one obligation you must do and one prohibition you must never do, laid on a hero and witnessed by others who will remember. It grants power exactly as long as it is kept, neither more nor less, and Cu Chulainn, the great warrior of Ulster, shows the pattern in his twin bonds, no dog meat and hospitality never refused, which made him untouchable until the day they collided on the road home.

The mechanism is human-sized, and that is why this book borrows it for your household without apology. A spoken rule with a witness, a stated cost for breaking, a rite of repair ready beforehand, thirty days long enough to change a groove and short enough to finish without despair. The tale-pattern is Attested as literary shape across the Irish stories; the thirty-day household use is Modern, labeled as such and fitted to a diary with trackers waiting ahead.

Draft your own pair tonight in pencil, small enough to keep and sharp enough to matter to you personally. One daily doing, one daily refusal, each fitting in a single breath when spoken aloud without rushing. Speak them to one witness, even if the witness is only this book held open on your knees, and let the thirty days begin tomorrow morning with the first tick.

Lore Root: geis-pattern across Irish tales — Attested as literary pattern; 30-day use — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *In your own words, what obligation and what prohibition would actually change you?*

Breaking and repair

Every hero breaks, because stories need the breaking the way bread needs salt to rise properly. What matters on this page is the repair-rite that follows the fall: name what broke, name what it cost in plain terms, make restitution one size larger than the damage, then speak the vow again or lay it down cleanly forever. No vagueness is allowed at any step of the four, since vague repair repairs nothing and only perfumes the wound for visitors.

Never stack punishment on shame, but do one mending act witnessed by this book and let the thread resume the next day like work after holiday. A geis repaired is stronger than one never tested, because it has survived contact with your real life and its weather rather than your intentions. The restitution-pattern is Reconstructed from the tales; the written repair-rite is Modern, plain and dated and fitted to these exact pages with their lines.

Rehearse it now before you need it, in four short lines you write tonight. What broke, what it cost, what mends it plus one size larger, the date the vow resumes its count. Under an hour to write and do, hands and pen, no special tools and no audience needed at all. The gate reopens when the mending is logged, not when the guilt finally fades, so log it promptly. Keep the four lines visible for the rest of the thirty days, as a map back in case the road slips again.

Lore Root: restitution-pattern in the tales — Reconstructed; repair-rite — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Imagine it broke tomorrow: what would honest repair look like for you?*

Choose your obligation: one thing you WILL do daily for 30 days. Small enough to keep. Write it as a vow.

Choose your prohibition: one thing you will NOT do for 30 days. Write it as a vow, with its cost.

Example vows that hold

Small holds; grand breaks, usually by Thursday of the first week. Good vows are embarrassingly small: walk twenty minutes, write three lines, speak no gossip, make the bed before breakfast, take no drink on weeknights, read one page with tea before bed. Smallness is the whole technology, because a vow you keep beats a vow that impresses, and the kept one compounds quietly while the grand one collapses and takes your confidence down with it.

Bad vows announce themselves just as clearly to anyone who listens with experience. Three new habits at once, anything needing another person's cooperation, anything your body has already vetoed, anything that requires a whole new life instead of a new line in the old one. The guidance here is Modern vow-craft, tested on kitchen tables rather than in tales, and it fails kindly and early by design so you can resize without shame.

Rewrite your pair until each fits in one breath, then begin today rather than Monday morning. One breath, one witness, one tick a day in the tracker ahead, no ceremony beyond starting and continuing. If a vow wobbles in week one, shrink it instead of quitting it, because the thread matters more than the size of the stitch. Begin small, stay small, finish whole and unsurprised. Copy the final pair onto the tracker's first page tonight, so the vow lives where the ticks will land.

Lore Root: vow-craft guidance — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Now write your final pair, obligation and prohibition, with each one fitting in a single breath.*

Mid-geis review, day fourteen: what holds, what drags, what needs repair already?

Geis tracker, days 1-14: mark each kept day. One line each.

- ☐ Day 1 — kept?
- ☐ Day 2 — kept?
- ☐ Day 3 — kept?
- ☐ Day 4 — kept?
- ☐ Day 5 — kept?
- ☐ Day 6 — kept?
- ☐ Day 7 — kept?
- ☐ Day 8 — kept?
- ☐ Day 9 — kept?
- ☐ Day 10 — kept?
- ☐ Day 11 — kept?
- ☐ Day 12 — kept?
- ☐ Day 13 — kept?
- ☐ Day 14 — kept?

Geis tracker, days 15-30: mark each kept day. Repair what broke.

- ☐ Day 15 — kept?
- ☐ Day 16 — kept?
- ☐ Day 17 — kept?
- ☐ Day 18 — kept?
- ☐ Day 19 — kept?
- ☐ Day 20 — kept?
- ☐ Day 21 — kept?
- ☐ Day 22 — kept?
- ☐ Day 23 — kept?
- ☐ Day 24 — kept?
- ☐ Day 25 — kept?
- ☐ Day 26 — kept?
- ☐ Day 27 — kept?
- ☐ Day 28 — kept? / Day 29-30 + repair note

An honest wheel

Picture a farming year in old Ireland, measured by the work in front of you rather than numbers on a wall. The calving and the lambing, the driving of herds to summer grass, the first grain cut, the harvest gathered before the dark closes in. The names for these turnings — Samhain, Imbolc, Beltane, Lughnasadh — survive in medieval Irish tales and in old glossaries where scribes paused to explain what each season word meant, with folk custom keeping bonfires and first loaves alive long after the manuscripts were shelved.

Treat these four as Irish ground you can stand on, and nothing wider. The familiar eight-point wheel you see in modern books, with solstices and equinoxes spaced evenly between the fires, was assembled in the last century out of several cultures at once. It is honest work on its own road, and this book simply walks a narrower one: four Gaelic fires, a Gaulish bronze calendar kept strictly to its own sidebar, and the moon watched for pleasure rather than forced into the pattern.

Start where your own year stands tonight. Find which of the four fires comes next on your calendar and mark it in ink, then read that fire's story pages once through with a cup of something warm. Before the week is out, choose one small preparation — a cleaned shelf, a loaf recipe, a name to invite — and write it beside the date. One marked fire and one kept preparation will teach you the wheel faster than any diagram.

Lore Root: four Gaelic fires in Irish sources — Attested; eight-spoke wheel — Modern synthesis.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look at your calendar and find which of the four fires comes next, then mark its date so you can prepare.*

How each fire works here

Every fire in this chapter keeps the same five rooms, so you always know which door you are opening. First the story as the old sources tell it, then the old practice as best we can recover it, then a modern rite sized for a flat and a single evening, then something for the table, and last a few ruled pages where your own hand takes over. Walk one fire all the way through before you peek at the next, the way you would walk a house from hearth to door.

Expect deliberately ordinary feasts, because the old festivals ran on food and fire and company rather than spectacle. You will meet the dumb supper — a quiet meal with one extra plate laid for the dead — beside first loaves, cleaned hearths, flower crowns, hill walks, and gratitude ledgers. Attested fragments and folk survival and modern invention each wear their labels here, so you always know which kind of ground each page stands on. When a page puzzles you, read its Lore Root line first — the label there settles what kind of ground you stand on.

Lay your own foundation before the first fire arrives. Sit down for twenty minutes with your notebook and list the dishes that already mean joy at your table — the birthday bread, the soup that fixes everything, the pudding someone always requests. Copy that list onto the reflection pages when you reach them. Your household already knows how to feast; this chapter only teaches it four old names.

Lore Root: chapter method — Modern, built on attested parts.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Think of how your household already feasts when it celebrates, and write down the dishes that mean joy at your table.*

The Coligny sidebar

In 1897 diggers at Coligny in France lifted shattered pieces of bronze from the soil, and scholars pieced them into the longest Gaulish text anyone owns. It holds a five-year calendar of sixty-two moon months with extra intercalary months — added leap months that keep the moons stepping alongside the sun — and its Gaulish month names stand in the cut-letter style of a Roman-era noticeboard. Hold that green-stained bronze in your mind: broken, painstakingly joined, and still arguing with everyone who reads it. Its months still march in bronze long after the hands that cut them turned to dust, which is reason enough to visit it with respect.

Read it as a Gaulish spotlight and nothing more, because specialists still disagree about how the bronze was ever used. Nothing on it maps onto Samhain or Beltane or any fire in this book, and it would be dishonest to borrow its age to gild our wheel. Admire it for what it attests — Gaulish month names, moon counting, Roman-period craft — and let the festivals stand on their separate Irish ground.

Borrow only its habit, which is moon-watching, and leave the reconstruction to the scholars. Tonight step outside and find the moon, note whether it waxes or wanes, and write one line about the sky over your street. Keep those notes going across the two months of the tracker on the next page. Wonder, logged twice a month, is the whole of this sidebar's work.

Lore Root: bronze, 62 lunar months, Roman-era style — Attested; festival use — unknown, scholars disagree.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Step outside tonight and find the moon, then note whether it is waxing or waning and what it is growing toward.*

Moon tracker, two months: watch, don't reconstruct. Note new and full dates.

- ☐ Month one, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one — what ripened with it?
- ☐ Month two, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two — what ripened with it?
- ☐ Which fire falls inside these two moons?
- ☐ One line: what did the moon teach?

The story: harvest ends, the dead draw near

At Samhain the harvest stands gathered and winter opens its mouth. The old Irish name means summer's end, and the medieval tales show you exactly what ending looked like: herds driven down from summer pasture, debts called in and settled, hearth fires put out to be kindled fresh, and the mounds — the old burial hills dotting the landscape — standing open so the dead walk near the living. Divination thickens at this hinge above all others, because winter asks hard questions about stores and stock, and you want counsel before the dark closes.

Folk custom carries the same shape forward in plainer clothes, and you can trust it as survival rather than scripture. A quieted house, the old names spoken aloud, one account closed before dark, an extra measure of care at the threshold. Nothing here needs a crowd or a costume or a hilltop. It needs a swept hearth, a clear table, and an honest reckoning of what the year grew and what it buried.

Keep one small audit in the week the fire falls on. Still the rooms for an evening, lay out your own year's ledger — what finished, what owes, what carries forward — and close a single account, whether a debt repaid, a drawer emptied, or a letter finally sent. Speak the names of your own dead over supper, one sentence each. That kept shape, repeated yearly, will carry you through the dark.

Lore Root: medieval Irish tales and folk custom — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Name one thing that ended for you this year, and write it down so it can be buried with honor.*

Old practice, modern rite

The old practice ran on assembly and audit, insofar as the tales and folk memory let us see it. People gathered, accounts between neighbors were settled before winter, and lots were cast or omens read to learn what the dark months intended. Picture a crowded hall with the harvest in and the doors barred early: that press of bodies, that smell of smoke and wet wool, that hunger to know what winter holds. Counsel-taking was the rite, because no household survives the cold on stores alone.

Your modern rite shrinks that hall to your own table without pretending to rebuild it. At its center stands the dumb supper — a quiet meal eaten with one extra plate laid for the dead — flanked by small ancestor cards, a sentence of thanks written for each name you honor, and a candle set in the doorway against the dark. Name the layers honestly: assembly and divination are attested, the plated quiet meal is folk survival, and the cards are a modern make that earns its place by working.

Hold it some evening this week in under an hour. Cook one simple dish, lay the extra plate, and eat slowly while you speak each honored name aloud with its thanks. Let the doorway candle burn steady as the rooms settle, then carry it room to room before you sleep. Repeat the same shape every year, and the dead will know the way back to your table.

Lore Root: assembly and divination — Attested; dumb supper and cards — Folk survival and Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Choose who receives a plate at your table this year, and decide what thanks you will speak to each one.*

For the table and the door

Cook from the stored harvest and keep it plain: apples and nuts, pork or a root stew that improves overnight, bread for sopping, whatever your cupboards already hold against winter. Set the extra plate with the rest of the table, serve it the same portion, and divide a share for the birds the next morning so the offering keeps moving through living mouths. Frugality is the feast here; the stores themselves are the decoration. Let the children, if any sit at your table, lay the extra plate themselves; work shared is memory kept.

After the meal comes the walking, and it borrows an old shape you already met at Beltane: herds once passed between two fires for protection, and your candlelit round of the rooms works the same pattern in miniature. Carry one flame from room to room, naming every member and sleeper under your roof as you go, and speak steady rather than grand. Protection laid over real names, out loud, in your own voice, is the oldest luck there is.

Draw your route before the night so the rite stays inside the hour. Sketch your flat room by room in the notebook, write each sleeper's name beside the room where they rest, and keep the whole walk under ten minutes. What takes planning is the list, not the walking — and a list made carefully lets the flame do the rest. Walk it once empty-handed before the night, timing yourself, so candles and names fit the evening without hurry.

Lore Root: harvest foods and fire-walking pattern — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Map your door to door route room by room, and list the names you will speak in each one.*

Reflection: what will you carry through the dark, and what stays buried here?

Reflection: what will you repeat every Samhain, even in a tired year?

The story: lambing, milk, Brigid

Midwinter's hinge arrives with small wet miracles rather than trumpets. The ewes lamb, and their milk comes back after winter's thin months — the old word for this season carries something like sheep-milking time inside it, squeezed from a glossary entry rather than sung in any epic. Later tradition calls it spring's beginning, though frost can still bite for weeks after the date. Picture the byre at first light: steam off the animals, a full pail where yesterday there was little, green tips nosing through black soil that still freezes overnight.

The same date carries Brigid's day, and two figures share the feast the way neighbors share a well. Brigid the goddess of poetry and smithcraft stands on the pagan side of the water; Brigid the Christian saint of Kildare stands on the other; the hinge itself belongs to neither and both. Honor it with milk in every form, a cleaned hearth, and the first green things brought indoors. Beginning, not finishing, is the whole of this fire's work.

Spend one short walk this week looking for beginnings rather than results. Find a single green shoot, a lengthening evening, a project stirring under its blanket, and give it one sentence in your notebook — no plan, no pressure, just witness. Early February asks only that you notice what quickens while winter still holds the fields.

Lore Root: milking-season gloss plus Brigid's day — Attested thinly; details — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Notice what is quickening early in you even while winter holds, and give it a sentence here.*

Old practice, modern rite

Of the four fires this one stands on the thinnest early ground, and honesty asks you to feel the floorboards creak. The medieval sources give you the milking-season gloss and Brigid's feast day, and little else you could build a rite on. So the modern practice leans on the hinge itself, frankly labeled as reconstruction: clean one thing completely, change every standing vessel of water in the flat, and set a single seed of intent for the spring. Small thoroughness, done on purpose, is the entire liturgy.

From rushes or straw you can weave a Brigid's cross for the door you use most — and know exactly what you hold. It is a folk-Christian craft hung for household protection, gathered up by custom into February, not a druid relic rescued from the Iron Age. The distinction flatters neither side; it simply keeps you from telling the cross a story it never lived. Hang it square over the lintel and let it do its neighborly work.

Choose your one cleaning tonight and name it in plain words: the junk drawer, the windowsill garden, the shelf that shames you. Give it thirty unhurried minutes — hot water, a cloth, rubbish bag at your elbow — and finish it entirely rather than starting three. When the space shines, write your seed intent on a slip and set the cross above it. Hinge cleaned, water changed, intention planted: that is Imbolc in a flat.

Lore Root: hinge-cleaning — Reconstructed; Brigid's cross — Folk-Christian blend, labeled.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Pick the one space you will clean as your Imbolc act, and name it plainly.*

For the table and the hearth

Feast on milk in every shape your kitchen keeps: buttered bread still warm, cheese cut thick, porridge drowned in cream, pancakes flipped fast and eaten faster. The old hinge ran on new milk after winter scarcity, so let richness itself be the ceremony and eat in the brightest room you own. Mass your candles against the February dark — every stub and tea light you can find — and keep the table lit like a small defiance while the meal lasts. If milk runs short in your house, let one good dairy thing carry the feast — butter on black bread is ceremony enough.

Eating done, the writing begins, and it takes five minutes that carry for months. Draft one seed intent on a slip of paper in plain words — a single sentence, a single growing thing — and set it where your eyes land daily until Beltane: mirror corner, kettle shelf, the door you open each morning. Folk survival gives you the milk foods; the dated slip is modern method. Both work better for being named as what they are.

Rough the sentence out on the reflection pages first, where crossings-out cost nothing. Trim it until a child could understand it, copy it fair onto a clean slip, and prop it where you promised yourself it would stand. Read it once each morning while the kettle boils. Tending one sentence for a season teaches more about intention than a shelf of new resolutions.

Lore Root: milk foods at the hinge — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Draft your seed intent here first in plain words, then copy it fair for the months ahead.*

Reflection: what craft — hands, words, or care — will you tend until spring?

Reflection: what will you repeat every Imbolc, even in a tired year?

The story: bonfires and the herds

Summer opens with fire, and an old Irish glossary hands you the picture to hold. Two bonfires were kindled close together on the hill, and the cattle were driven between the twin flames to guard them from disease before they turned out to summer pasture. Thresholds stood garlanded meanwhile, doors dressed with green branches and May flowers, the whole farmstead wearing its summer clothes at once. Hear it before you see it: lowing beasts, crackling gorse, shouting drovers, smoke flattening across the slope in the May wind.

Joy and protection walked the day together, and that pairing is the teaching. Celebration never left the gate unbarred: the herd blessed going out, the doors greened behind them, every threshold named and dressed. Translate the herd directly to your household — its members, its animals, its sleepers — and bless them the same way, by name and out loud. The glossary account is attested; the garlanding lives on as folk survival; your spoken blessing joins them as modern household craft.

Walk your own thresholds this week and choose one to dress. It can be your front door, a garden gate, or a turning in your life that needs greening — a new job, a healed quarrel, a room reclaimed. Gather whatever green the week offers, weeds welcome, and fix it over the lintel with string. Stand under it, speak the names of everyone inside your hedge, and let summer find you ready.

Lore Root: glossary bonfire account — Attested; garlanding — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Choose which doorway of yours needs garlanding this year, whether it is a real door or a turning in your life.*

Old practice, modern rite

Long ago the practice centered on the need fire and the passage between flames, with living beasts walking a corridor of heat while watchers prayed the smoke would carry sickness off. Your modern rite keeps the boundary-walk and sets the flames safely down. Carry one candle round your whole dwelling — garden and flat and hallway included — moving sunwise if your rooms allow it, and name every member and animal and sleeper inside your hedge of protection as you pass their doors.

Then comes the greening, which is the day's delight. Dress one doorway with living branches and crown yourself with whatever flowers the week offers, weeds included and welcome, twisted into a circlet that will not survive the evening. For fire itself take the safe version only, frankly modern: hold hands together over a candle flame, or step carefully over a low candle set in a cleared space. Never light a bonfire indoors, never carry flame near curtains, never leave it unwatched — the old need fire served the herd, and yours serves the household's safety first.

Write your hedge-list before you lift the candle. Name everyone who belongs inside your protection this summer — people, pets, the friend sleeping on your sofa through the hard month — and speak each name once through to check it sits right. Carry that list on your walk and read from it rather than trusting memory. Blessing works best written down first and spoken aloud after.

Lore Root: boundary-walking and green-dressing — Folk survival; candle-step — Modern safe version.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *List who belongs inside your hedge of protection this summer, and speak each name with care.*

For the table and the crown

Set the year's first fresh things on the table and let them argue with winter's memory. Green salads still gritty from the garden, new cheese, oatcakes running with honey, something grilled over flame if your means allow — a rasher, a skewer of vegetables, marshmallows on a fork over a candle for the flat-bound. Eat near the light, hearth or grill or massed candles, and let the meal run past its usual hour into the long May evening.

Make the crown whether you feast alone or among dozens, because the making is the rite. Twist green branches into a rough circlet, tuck in whatever blooms the week gave you, and wear it through the whole meal before hanging it on your dressed door. Folk survival gives you the May greens and the communal eating; the solo crown reworn as door gift is modern joy. Pleasure without apology is the Beltane rule — take your portion with both hands. Hang the wilted crown on the outside of your dressed door next morning, where neighbors and weather can finish it.

Claim one pleasure tonight in writing before the feast begins. Name it plainly on the reflection page — the nap in the sun, the second helping, the dance track played loud with windows open — and grant it without bargaining or penance attached. Beltane keeps its promise to households that let themselves enjoy it fully. Write it before the feast, not after; pleasures claimed hungry taste better than pleasures excused full.

Lore Root: May greens and communal eating — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Name one pleasure you will allow yourself this Beltane, and claim it without apology.*

Reflection: write the household blessing you spoke, naming its names.

Reflection: what will you repeat every Beltane, even in a tired year?

The story: Lugh's games, first harvest

This feast carries Lugh's name — the Irish god of many skills and crafts — and his assembly gives it its flavor. Medieval accounts describe games and fairs and horse racing, first loaves cut from the new grain, and hill climbs at Tailtiu, the great assembly mound in Meath where the provinces once showed their strength. Picture the slope on fair day: dust, shouting, sweat, horses strung bright, loaves broken open while still warm, every craft from smithing to storytelling set out for judging. Work displayed, trials run, first fruits tasted with their story told aloud.

Gratitude with sore feet is the day's signature, and it translates cleanly to any household. Climb something, compete kindly against your own last year, and share whatever surplus the season put in your hands. Thank everyone whose labor fed you, and make the thanks specific — the grower, the carrier, the cook, the weather that behaved. First fruits mean nothing until somebody names the hands behind them. Specific thanks outlast the feast; vague gratitude evaporates with the washing-up.

Name one skill of yours to show at this harvest, however modest. The loaf you finally mastered, the mended shirt, the spreadsheet that saved your team hours — display it to one witness and share its yield. Write down how you will share it before the week ends. A skill shown and shared is Lughnasadh kept in miniature.

Lore Root: medieval accounts of games and first fruits — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Pick one skill of yours that deserves a small showing at this harvest, and name how you will share it.*

Old practice, modern rite

Old practice meant the fair and the climb: uphill on foot with the crowds, contests run in the open, the year's work judged where everyone could see it. Your modern rite keeps both at a size your week can hold. Walk uphill far enough to feel it in your legs — your hill can be small, a park slope or a stairwell counted honestly — and run one contest with yourself by repeating exactly what you attempted last year and counting the result aloud. Count out loud and write the figure down at once; memory flatters, ink does not.

Taste one first-fruit loaf on purpose, whether you baked it, bought it, or begged it off a neighbor's plenty. Then make your oaths the way fairs made them: one promise spoken before witnesses, however few, with your work standing beside your word. Games and vows were always a single event at the assembly, trial and pledge in the same breath. A vow spoken over shared bread holds tighter than one whispered alone. Stand when you speak it, feet on the floor, loaf in sight — small theater, honestly meant.

Fix your contest tonight so it fits inside the hour. Pick the task, write its simple rules in three lines — what counts, how you score, when it ends — and run it this week against your own last mark. Log the number honestly, win or lose. The ledger remembers what pride forgets, and next year's fair starts from that line.

Lore Root: hill climbs and contests — Attested in accounts; home version — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Decide what contest you will run with yourself this harvest, and write its simple rules.*

For the table and the ledger

Open the feast with new bread and butter, because this is the first grain and it deserves pride of place. Add berries and early apples, corn however you like it, and anything your neighbors press on you from their own plenty. Tell each dish's story at the table the way the assemblies told provenance: who grew it, how far it traveled, what weather raised it. First fruits eaten with their history taste of more than flour. If your table is small, let one perfect loaf and one honest story carry the whole feast.

Close the meal by opening the gratitude ledger, kept in the notebook rather than the purse. Name every hand between soil and plate — growers and carriers and cooks and the weather itself, which did its share unasked. Then set this week's surplus aside for giving, because harvest only finishes when it is shared. Reconstructed from old accounts, this tasting-with-provenance still does the old work: it binds the eater to the fed. Read the ledger aloud before the giving, so every named hand is thanked twice — once in ink, once in air.

List three hands that fed you this year and match each with a thanks you can deliver. A note posted, a jar carried round, a bill paid early with gratitude said aloud — choose what fits your means and do it before the month turns. Shared surplus closes the circle the hill climb opened.

Lore Root: first-fruit tasting with provenance — Reconstructed from accounts.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *List three hands that fed you this year, and choose how you will thank each one.*

Reflection: what will you finish before the light turns?

Reflection: what will you repeat every Lughnasadh, even in a tired year?

Safety box — read first

Some of the old plants in this chapter can kill you, so you read this page first and take it to heart. Yew and mistletoe berries and selago, which is the old name for fir clubmoss, a low evergreen herb, are toxic, and you never ingest anything from these pages on a book's authority alone. You do no wild identification without an expert beside you, you use store-bought teas only, and you check every herb against your medicines and, if relevant, against pregnancy with a clinician first.

Your rule for the chapter is simple, and it keeps you safe while you learn. You hang and journal freely, but you brew cautiously, and you meet yew and mistletoe and selago and samolus, which is the old brookweed of wet ditches, with eyes and notebook only. The old texts describe real poisonings alongside real cures, and only the cautious got to write sequels.

Lore Root: toxicity and caution — Attested classical and modern medical fact.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Write your own safety line here, naming what you will never ingest and who your expert will be.*

Mistletoe on oak — hang only

Pliny the Elder — a Roman writer whose Natural History preserves much of what outsiders claimed about Gaul — gives you the scene to hold. Robed priests climb an oak bearing mistletoe, cut the sprig with a golden sickle, and catch it in a white cloth before it can touch the ground, because the gathering served as fertility rite and cure-all collection at once. Later books prescribed the plant against everything from fits to poison, an antidote lore that ran for centuries on the strength of that first strange picture.

Treat the picture as report, not recipe. The berries are toxic, the plant stands protected in some places, and no page in this book will ever ask you to brew or swallow it. Its household meaning is threshold magic only: a bought sprig hung over the door at midwinter, left to preside over the dark weeks, then composted when the season turns. The old rite stays on the lintel where it belongs, beautiful and untouched.

Buy one sprig this midwinter from a market stall or garden shop — never cut wild without knowing the local law — and hang it over your most-used door with string. Note the date you hung it and the date you composted it, one line each. If you spot mistletoe in the wild, write down the host tree instead of reaching: oak, apple, and hawthorn each tell their own story.

Lore Root: Pliny's Natural History account — Attested classical report.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *When did you last spot mistletoe in the wild, and which tree was holding it?*

Vervain of the altar

Vervain is a slender wayside herb with small lilac flowers, easy to walk past and hard to forget once learned. Roman writers and later folk custom agree on its station: it was gathered with prayers, carried for protection, and laid on altars at midsummer, while the old herbals — the big books of plant remedies — assigned it in equal measure to headaches and stones and low spirits. Picture the bundle on the altar stone, grey-green against white linen: ceremony made visible in weeds. Altar herb, headache herb, protection herb: three jobs, one weed, and centuries of customers at the stall.

Read those old assignments as history rather than prescription, because this book gives no doses and treats no ailments. Your use stays small and bought: a pinch of shop-bought dried herb in a cup of tea, or a sprig tucked into the charm bag on a later page, logged with day and amount the way an apprentice kept the shop book. Never as a substitute for prescribed medicine, and check with a clinician first if you take regular medicines or could be pregnant.

Learn it by looking before you ever buy. Find a clear photograph or a garden specimen, study the toothed leaves and the thin lilac spikes for ten minutes, then sketch what you saw here in words — five lines, plain description, no poetry required. A plant drawn in sentences stays known longer than one merely read about.

Lore Root: classical and herbal altar-use — Attested in old herbals.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look up vervain's leaf in a garden or online, then sketch what you see here in words.*

Selago, fir clubmoss — journal only

Selago — the old name for fir clubmoss, a low evergreen like tiny fir branches pressed close to the ground — takes the strangest harvest rite in any book you will meet here. Pliny says it was gathered barefoot and bare-handed, lifted in a white cloth under strict rules, and carried home in secret without meeting any eye along the path. However much of that ceremony you credit, the strangeness tells you something true: the gatherers handled this plant as though it mattered enormously.

What matters now is leaving it alone. Fir clubmoss is protected and uncommon in many places, and it is toxic besides — so this one lives in your journal and nowhere else. Learn its look from photographs, note where it grows near you if it grows at all, and let knowing stand in for keeping. Modern conservation joins the old secrecy here: both say the plant stays where it stands. Your notebook entry — date, place, weather, one sketched frond — is the modern white cloth you carry it home in.

Lend it one quiet research evening inside the hour. Look up which protected plants grow closest to your home, pick one, and plan a visit that touches nothing — bus route, path, season to see it at its best. Write the plan down. Some rites consist entirely of showing up, looking hard, and walking away empty-handed. Bring nothing back but the plan and, later, the memory of green against stone.

Lore Root: Pliny's gathering account — Attested classical report; non-use — Modern conservation.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Which protected plant grows closest to where you live, and how can you visit it without touching?*

Samolus, brookweed — journal only

Samolus — the old name for brookweed, a small plant of wet ditches and stream edges — comes down to you with a charm still tied round its stem. Pliny reports that Gaulish gatherers lifted it fasting and with the left hand, without looking at it, and fasting folk at dawn beside a cold ditch is a scene you can picture whether or not you credit the method. The picture itself is the inheritance: a plant best admired exactly where it stands.

Leave this one to the journal as well, for reasons both old and new. Its ditches are fragile ground that trampling ruins, and the gathering lore reads as ritual theater rather than instruction any household should follow. Find its habitat on a walk and note the water it keeps — depth, flow, what grows alongside. Draw the ditch rather than the dose, because some plants teach entirely by refusing to be used. Wet ground keeps its own counsel; your job is to listen with dry socks and a sharp pencil.

Take one walk this week along a wet ditch or stream edge, boots on and notebook bagged against the damp. Record what grows where the water stands: three plants named if you can name them, sketched if you cannot. Twenty minutes of bankside attention will teach you more about samolus than any gathered specimen, and the ditch keeps everything it had. Mark the waterline while you are there — ditch plants live and die by an inch of rain either way.

Lore Root: Pliny's gathering account — Attested classical report; non-use — Modern conservation.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Take a walk along one wet ditch or stream edge, and record what you find growing where the water stands.*

Meadowsweet, wound herb of the Brehon laws

Meadowsweet sweetens the damp meadows in high summer: creamy flower heads nodding over the ditches, an almond-sweet scent you can smell before you see the plant. It stood high enough to be named in the Brehon laws — the old Irish law books that set prices on wound herbs and their proper use — and folk custom kept it afterward for mead flavoring and summer cordials and aching heads. Stand downwind of a full stand once, and you will understand why neither lawyers nor housewives let it go.

Standing in law books is honor, not prescription, so keep your own use small, bought, and written down. Take bought dried flowers only, a single cup logged with date and amount, and never as a substitute for anything your doctor prescribed — the plant grows in aspirin country, chemically speaking, which is exactly why anyone on regular medicines should check with a clinician first. Write that caution twice in your notebook. Respect for the plant includes respect for your doctor.

Brew one cup of bought meadowsweet tea some unhurried afternoon and give it your full attention for fifteen minutes. Note what the scent reminds you of — almond, hayfield, summer river — and write three lines before the cup cools. A cordial season can wait for summer; a single tasted cup, honestly logged, is this month's whole practice.

Lore Root: Brehon law listing plus folk tea-use — Attested and Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Brew one cup of bought meadowsweet tea, then write down what its scent reminds you of.*

Yarrow for staunching

Yarrow is easy to know once you learn its signature: feathery leaves like green lace, flat white flower heads riding along hedges and verges all through summer. Old books call it soldier's woundwort and lend it Achilles' name, because the folk use runs the same across countries — staunching. A pinched leaf for nosebleeds, a clean field plaster where custom and law permit, pressure and patience in green form. Walk any old footpath in July and you will pass a dozen stands without noticing until the day you need one.

Let respect run ahead of use with this one, because the plant that staunches can also sensitize. Wear gloves for handling, try a patch test first if your skin runs reactive, and keep use to the outside of the body for tiny cuts only — or bought tea in the cup, logged like everything else. Never as a substitute for prescribed medicine, never for anything deep or dirty or doubtful. Care comes before lore, and lore itself says so.

Count first and gather later, if you gather at all. On your next walk tally every stand you pass and note where the ground runs damp or trodden, because yarrow's address book teaches what the herbals cannot: where it lives near you, and in what company. Ten counted stands and one sketched leaf will ground the plant better than a pressed specimen ever could.

Lore Root: wound-use across classical and folk sources — Attested pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *On your next walk, look for yarrow by its feathery leaf and count how many stands you pass.*

Mugwort for the traveler

Mugwort haunts roadsides and waste ground: a bitter, grey-green herb with pale leaf undersides, common as gossip and twice as traveled. Folk custom sets it walking with wayfarers — tucked in shoes against weariness on long roads — and hangs it over doors against whatever the night carries. Stuffed into dream pillows it promises vivid nights, and dreamers have kept that appointment for centuries. You likely pass it weekly without a glance; this page asks you to stop.

Work the pillow way, which asks nothing of your stomach. Sew a spoonful of dried bought herb into a small cloth bag, slip it under your pillow for a week, and log whatever dreams come in your Otherworld pages. Two cautions ride along, both non-negotiable: keep clear of it in pregnancy, and keep expectations modest — vivid is a hope, not a promise. Write the pregnancy line out and underline it before you begin.

Run the week cleanly so the notes mean something. Keep bedtime steady, the bag in place, and a pencil with the dream log for seven mornings running. At week's end read the entries straight through and mark anything that shifted — color, company, weather indoors. Whatever moved, you now hold a traveler's herb and a traveler's record to show for it. If the week yields nothing vivid, log that too; a clean negative keeps the record honest for the next trial.

Lore Root: traveler and dream lore — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Spend a week sleeping with mugwort tucked nearby, then note what shifted in your dream log.*

Nettle that stings and feeds

Nettle is the sting you already know, and it repays gloves with interest. Spring tops go into soup, dried leaf brews a dark iron-rich tea, stripped stems twist into cordage, and half the farmyard lines up for it as fodder. Few plants pack so plain a moral: the one that stings careless hands feeds careful ones. Find a spring patch raising its first flagons of green, and you have found a whole teacher standing in the weeds. Even the sting has its office: it teaches the glove, and the glove teaches every other care you own.

Gloves come before lore with this plant, full stop. Take the soup way only from young tops you can identify with certainty — and certainty means an expert confirmed you at least once — or brew bought dried leaf instead, logged with date and amount. Know your sting remedies before you lift the pot: dock leaf, cold water, patience. A household that respects the sting earns the feeding; the order never runs the other way.

Taste the lesson inside the hour this spring. Heat one pot of bought-leaf tea or, expert-confirmed, young-top soup, and eat or drink it slowly enough to taste the iron underneath the green. While it cools, name your human nettle on the reflection page — the one that stings but feeds you — and write what the gloves look like there. Two nettles honored, plant and person, before the pot is washed.

Lore Root: food and fiber use — Attested and Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Think of a nettle in your own life that stings but feeds you, and name the plant and the person alike.*

Elderflower cordial season

Elderflower arrives all at once in early summer, and the hedges foam white as though the year exhaled. Folk custom turns the flood straight into cordial and champagne and fritters eaten hot from the pan. The elder herself is treated as a lady to be asked before cutting — so speak your thanks before you take even a head of bloom, and take only what the season presses on you. A tree greeted properly gives twice: flowers now, berries after. Children sent out with bowls come back stained and triumphant; the season recruits its own pickers.

Those berries follow for syrups, and here the rule hardens: cook them always, because raw berries in any quantity and all green parts stay out of the pot. Work the cordial way as the safe way — bought or expert-confirmed flowers, sugar, lemon, three days steeping — and keep every batch labeled with its date. Folk survival gives you the recipe shapes; modern caution draws the lines round them. Sweetness keeps best inside boundaries. Label every jar with flower date and bush, because next winter you will want to remember which June you drank.

Save the making for next June if the month is wrong for flowers. Pick two elders near your walking route and visit them monthly from first bloom to last berry, one line each visit: date, stage, weather. By autumn you will hold a full cordial-season calendar of your own ground — and next June you will know exactly where to ask first.

Lore Root: elder cordial and asking-custom — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Watch the elders near you this year, and write down the season from first bloom to last.*

First meetings: which two plants from these pages will be your allies this year, and why?

First meetings: where exactly do they grow, and when will you visit each across the seasons?

Oak, the slow king

Oak measures time in centuries, and you feel the difference the moment you stand beneath one. It gave door-post wood and roof beams, stood its ground when lightning struck it hollow, and sits at the center of old stories the way a great table centers a hall — while Pliny's mistletoe rite hangs in its branches and travelers still leave lone oaks standing in cleared fields out of something older than habit. Put your palm to that bark: ridged, cold, unhurried. That slowness is the teaching.

Work oak slow, because nothing about this tree hurries and neither should you. Choose one long thing in your life — a skill, a repair, a saving — and give it oak patience: small steady attention, no forcing, seasons not weeks. Visit one local oak across all four fires and log it like an old friend: girth guessed, birds noted, your own news told briefly. Steadiness is a practice before it is a virtue. Tell the tree your news briefly on each visit; spoken aloud, your own seasons sound steadier.

Adopt your oak this week in twenty minutes. Walk to the nearest one worth the name, note exactly where it stands and how it looks today — lean, load, light through the crown — and write the description down as your first entry. Four fires from now, read that line back under the same branches. The tree will have changed less than you, and that is precisely the comfort.

Lore Root: central-tree pattern in tales and rites — Attested pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Choose one oak near you to adopt, and describe where it stands and how it looks today.*

Hazel of wisdom

Hazel carries wisdom in the Irish stories, and you meet it wherever water gathers — beside pools and holy wells, leaning over the current. Its nuts drop into the well of knowledge where the salmon eat them and grow wise in their spotted skins, while poets chew hazel for inspiration and coppice workers cut its rods for baskets and dowsing. One small tree feeding minds and hands alike: crack a ripe nut between your teeth in autumn and taste the whole arrangement working. Autumn nuts fall free for anyone who walks the banks; fill a pocket, crack them on a stone, and share.

Carry one question the hazel way: for a full month, and fed deliberately. Give it one reading, one conversation, and one walk per week — no more forcing than that, no nightly wrestling. Wisdom arrives the way hazel gives: as food, as craft, as a sentence dropped mid-conversation that rearranges the furniture. It never comes as lightning, whatever the tales suggest about sudden salmon-gained brilliance.

Look back over this month and name one piece of wisdom that arrived by those slow roads. Write where it came from — which meal, which making, which talk — and thank the giver by name if one stands behind it. A single logged instance teaches the pattern; next month you can carry your question on purpose instead of by accident. Date the entry; wisdom with a date on it compounds like interest.

Lore Root: hazel-wisdom complex in Irish tales — Attested literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look back over this month, and name one piece of wisdom that came as food, craft, or conversation.*

Rowan against harm

Rowan reddens over thresholds all across the northern countries, and you will find it planted deliberately by houses and holy wells. Old custom trusts it on doorways and gateposts and cradles alike — small tree, light crown, berries scarlet against grey stone — carrying a reputation for turning harm aside far larger than its timber. Spot the next one you pass: odds are it stands within arm's reach of somebody's door, and that placement is never accident.

Thresholds you name and tend hold better than thresholds you only lock, and rowan is the tending made visible. Plant or pot one where you can, or carry a fallen twig — fallen, never cut from a living tree without leave — in a small doorway bag with a written blessing. Folk survival gives you the custom; the daily noticing is yours. A guarded door you greet each morning works harder than any charm you forget by noon. Touch the frame each morning as you leave; the habit outlasts the berries and does half the work.

Consider the thresholds in your life tonight and name the one that most needs rowan steadiness. Front door, bedroom, inbox, temper — pick one, write its name down, and give it a week of deliberate greeting: hand on the frame, one steady breath, one kind sentence. Small trees guard by standing; you can do the same at your own doors. End the week by writing what changed at the threshold — mood, traffic, temper, luck.

Lore Root: threshold-protection custom — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Consider the thresholds in your life, and name which one most needs rowan steadiness now.*

Hawthorn, the fairy tree

Hawthorn flowers white at May, and across Ireland and Britain you will see lone thorns standing in cleared fields that no farmer will touch. It is the fairy tree, dangerous to cut — above all alone — and the stories punish those who forget with a steady inventiveness that kept more than one hedgerow standing. Walk up to one in full bloom and the reason lands bodily: scent thick as almond cake, branches loud with bees, blossom heaped like weather. Respect arrives unasked.

Handle hawthorn careful, which mostly means working it by leaving it be. Observe and never cut the lone tree, ask before taking even a sprig of blossom, and note its flowering date every year in the same notebook. May comes when the hawthorn says so and not a day before — a piece of folk phenology sharper than most wall calendars. The custom is still live, neighbors still watching; behave as though the field has eyes, because socially speaking it does.

Find your nearest hawthorn this week and make its acquaintance properly. Record exactly where it grows, how it stands — lone, hedged, or garden-kept — and the date you saw it, flower or thorn. Return at May blossom and add one line. A tree visited yearly becomes a fixed point, and fixed points are what wheels are hung on. Take no blossom on the first visit; introduction before asking is manners everywhere, fairy ground included.

Lore Root: lone-thorn avoidance — Folk survival, still live custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Find the hawthorn nearest to you, and record where it grows and when it flowers.*

Yew of the ancestors — no ingest

Yew outlives every tree around it, and you meet it where the long dead lie: churchyard guardian, ancestor tree, dark green against grey stone through every month of the year. Its wood gave bows and vessels to generations who respected it, and the old texts knew clearly what modern botany confirms — every part of yew is poison. Take no teas, no berries, no experiments; let the old lore stay on the page and out of your cup, your pot, and your hands.

Remembrance, not use, is this tree's household meaning. Visit churchyard or garden yews and sit a while with whoever comes to mind, carrying nothing away but notes — no clippings, no berries, no bark. Counsel belongs under oak, as an earlier page taught; remembrance belongs under yew, and honoring that division keeps both trees, and you, in good health. Attested fact grounds the reverence: toxic evergreen, ancestral shade, patience made woody. Bring children here too, and teach them the rule young: look, remember, touch nothing, take nothing.

Give ten quiet minutes beside a yew or old evergreen this week, phone pocketed and notebook open. Sit within sight of the branches, let names surface without chasing them, and afterward write down who came to mind in a single honest line. No rite, no request, no reaching. Presence is the practice, and the ancestors ask nothing more expensive.

Lore Root: yew-ancestor association plus toxicity — Attested fact.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Give ten quiet minutes beside a yew or old evergreen, then write down who came to mind.*

Plant ally log: your chosen ally across the four fires. First entry — leaf, flower, seed, date.

Seasonal gathering calendar: what will you gather, where, and in which month? Ask-first rule noted.

My tea, charm, and bath record: what you made, bought or wild-expert, dose, date, effect.

Wells that remember

Picture the mud of a lakebed holding bronze swords and cauldrons and scattered coins, laid down by hands across thousands of years. Divers and diggers keep finding them where rivers slow and springs rise, and scholars call these placed gifts votive deposits. The custom never fully died. On pattern days at holy wells you can still watch people walk the round, pray their stations in order, and knot rags to the thorn above the water, while the water itself holds this memory longer than any record book. Some gifts went in whole and some bent or broken, as if the giving mattered more than the keeping.

Read the well as a neighbor with a long memory, not a machine that grants wishes. The old deposits are attested, lifted from the ground and catalogued shelf by shelf. The rounds and the rag trees are living folk custom, kept by the families who tend each site and know its days. Tossing coins into a living spring is a newer visitor habit, and the metal fouls the water it pretends to honor, so leave that part out. When in doubt, watch what the keepers do and follow their lead before your own impulse.

Your nearest spring or city well can be visited in under an hour with nothing in your pockets. Walk quietly, follow the round as it is kept there, or circle once sunwise where no round is marked. Tie only cloth that will rot away on its own, ask leave before you lift any water, and sit a while at the edge to listen before you leave. Where the well is built over or capped, stand at the nearest marked place and pay your attention there instead.

Lore Root: votive deposits plus living well-custom — Attested and Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Which spring or well is nearest you, and on what day will you go and see it?*

Fords where laws hold

The river runs shallow over gravel, and an army must cross single file. In the great old Irish tale called the Tain, the young hero Cu Chulainn holds one such ford alone against the armies of Connacht, meeting each challenger man to man while the rest wait their turn at the banks. A ford belongs to neither side, and the storytellers loved that narrow ground, setting their hardest bargains and single combats where the water runs thin. The armies camp on either bank and watch, because the ford makes a courtroom of the river.

Midstream has its own rule: neither bank owns the middle, so everyone must state terms in the open and keep them. Your own fords work the same way: the half-left job, the half-bought house, the sentence half said. Name what you are leaving and what you are carrying while you stand midstream, instead of sleepwalking to the far side. Speak your terms out loud while the water is still around your ankles.

Take twenty minutes at your table with paper and pen. Write the crossing you are inside right now, the bank behind you, and the bank ahead. List one thing you will carry over and one you will set down in the water, read the page aloud once, and keep it folded where you dress each morning until the crossing ends. Burn nothing and bury nothing; the paper is only a marker, and the speaking is the rite.

Lore Root: ford as boundary-battle place, Tain pattern — Attested literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Describe the crossing you are in the middle of now, and name the bank you are leaving behind.*

Doorways you own

Every threshold you step through is a small ford between out and in. Folk custom has always treated it that way: rowan sprigs nailed above the lintel, a pinch of salt along the sill, a verse sung going out and a pause for breath coming home. You cross that line a dozen times a day without noticing, and the old habit asks you to notice just once, with your hand on the frame. Stand in your own frame tonight and feel how the air changes on either side of the line.

That doorway marks the edge of your household the way a bank marks a river, and small care there steadies everything inside. The rowan and the salt and the verses are folk survivals, gathered from many districts rather than one single rite. A modern monthly keeping, clean and dress and speak, gives those scattered scraps a shape your calendar can hold. The door you keep becomes the standard for the rest: what holds at the threshold spreads inward.

Pick the door you use most and give it fifteen minutes this week. Scrub the sill, clear the corners, hang a sprig of green that suits your street. Choose one short line for leaving and one for returning, and say them daily for a month. Small repetition does what grandeur cannot. Photograph the dressed doorway for your journal, then leave the keeping to hands and voice rather than the camera.

Lore Root: threshold-keeping across folk custom — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Which doorway will you keep, and what two short lines will it hear from you?*

Dawn, dusk, and Samhain Eve

Twice a day the light stands neither here nor there, and once a year the season does the same. At Samhain Eve, summer's end, the old Irish tales say the mounds, the grass-covered burial hills, stood open and the dead walked near. Dawn and dusk carry the smaller daily version of that opening, when the house is quiet and the edges of things show themselves plainly. Stand out in it once and feel the day change hands, with birds passing the watch from one shift to the other. Even a city window will do.

Edges were treated as meeting times, when bargains get struck and messages pass, and the tales return to that pattern again and again. That pattern is attested across story after story. The phrase thin places for such spots is modern, a recent coinage worth labeling, but the habit underneath is older: pay attention at the seams of the day and something in you answers. No doctrine is asked of you here, only punctuality: show up at the edge and pay attention.

Keep three dawns or three dusks in a row, ten minutes each, at a window or a step. Watch the light change and count three sounds before you go back inside. Write a dated line or two after each sit, and by the third day you will know whether dawn or dusk is yours. Where cloud hides the sun, keep the hour anyway; the edge holds even when you cannot see it.

Lore Root: edge-meetings in tale and custom — Attested pattern; thin-place term — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Will you sit at dawn or at dusk, and which three days will you keep?*

Well visit: go, clean, listen. Date, place, what you cleared, what you heard, what you left.

Ford worksheet: what you are crossing, what you carry over, what you set down mid-river.

The doorway rite

Set aside four minutes at the door you use most, once a month or at each fire festival. Sweep the sill clean down to the bare step and lay a fresh line of salt where the step meets the street. Set rowan above the lintel where rowan grows, rosemary where it does not. Stand inside a breath, then speak or sing one verse as you step out into the day. Move briskly and speak plainly; the rite wants care, not ceremony.

Each part carries its household sense, drawn from folk custom rather than one old book. The sweeping clears stale passage, the salt marks the line, the green over the lintel signs the house awake. The verse going out and the thanks coming home frame the day the way banks frame a ford, and the monthly shape holding it all is modern, honestly labeled so. Nothing is burned, nothing is buried, and nothing leaves the house but stale dust. The broom does half the blessing before a word is said.

Coming home, halt in the frame itself for one breath and one thanks, and mark what the light is doing as you stand there. Four minutes is the whole of it, going and coming both. Write your two lines down tonight so they stand ready when the month turns. Miss a month and you have lost nothing; sweep, salt, green, and verse begin again without penalty. Four minutes, once a month: even the busiest house can hold that.

Lore Root: threshold elements across folk custom — Folk survival; monthly shape — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Write out your short going out verse and your coming home thanks, so both are ready to keep.*

Three-day sit log: dawn OR dusk, three days. Light, sounds, what shifted — dated.

Stones with strokes

Run your finger along the edge of an Irish standing stone and you may find short strokes cut in bundles along a center line. That is ogham, an early medieval Irish alphabet whose stones stand roughly from the fourth through sixth centuries, most of them naming a man as somebody's son in plain words. Later scribes copied the alphabet into manuscripts and kept it alive on vellum after the carving stopped. You can see them still in Irish fields and museums, weathered but legible where the light rakes sideways.

Centuries later, medieval poets joined each letter to a tree with a riddle verse, the kennings: birch for Beith, rowan for Luis, on through the grove. Those tree lists are attested in the manuscripts, yet they come from poets rather than from the stones themselves. Casting sticks to tell fortunes is a modern game laid over the old alphabet, pleasant at the table but always labeled modern. Learn the difference by handling: the stones give names, the poets give trees, and your own sticks give counsel.

Copy one letter slowly in your journal with a ruler for the stem line. Count its strokes, sound its name aloud, and note what the shape brings to mind before any meaning. One letter a week through the month teaches your hand what no list can. Date each copy and say the sound aloud; the alphabet enters through hand and mouth together.

Lore Root: stones 4th-6th c. plus medieval tree lists — Attested; oracle use — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Copy one ogham letter slowly here. What do its strokes bring to mind before any meaning?*

Seven fews for divination

Seven short strokes of the old alphabet are all this book asks you to learn, and the tradition calls each letter a few. Birch for beginnings, rowan for protection, alder for standing firm where the ground is soft. Willow for water and moon and grief, ash for the links between worlds, hawthorn for the hindrance that guards, holly for outlasting the hard season. Say each name aloud until the sounds sit easy on your tongue. Copy the seven onto slips of card tonight, the name on one side and the meaning on the other.

Those letter names and tree joins come from the medieval lists, honestly attested there. Everything else in this working, the narrowed set of seven and the three-few spread of root and trunk and branch, is modern, built for journal reflection rather than old divination. Call it what it is and it stays clean: a modern mirror in an old wooden frame. Nothing here pretends to old divination, and that honesty is what keeps the working trustworthy.

Boil your question down to one written line tonight, then draw three fews from slips of paper and lay them left to right. The root shows what grounds the matter, the trunk what stands firm, the branch what may grow. Date the cast, write three plain sentences, and read it back at the next fire before you draw again. Keep every cast in the same pages, and patterns will surface across the months that one night cannot show.

Lore Root: letter meanings from medieval lists — Attested lists; spread and divination — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *For one true question tonight, draw three fews. What are your root, trunk, and branch?*

The triskele is old; the rest is newer

Three arms turn together on stone older than any church in the parish. The triskele, the triple spiral, is cut on Iron Age metalwork of the La Tene style, the flowing art of Gaul and Britain, and on stones raised long before. It honors threes that matter: land and sea and sky, or three of your own choosing. Trace one slowly and your hand learns the turn better than your eyes ever will. Some carved stones are older still, raised long before iron was ever worked. Your hand joins a long line of hands each time you trace the turn.

Leave the rest of the famous swirls where they belong. The triquetra with its three pointed loops, the shield knot, and most tangled knotwork sold as a druid badge belong to Early Christian and medieval art, the world of the Book of Kells, or to frankly modern craft. Draw them gladly as craft, and never call them druidic. One spiral here is Iron Age; the rest is newer. Loving them as craft takes nothing from them; misnaming them only clouds the water.

Sketch your triskele on paper first, three arms turning the same way, in under half an hour. Try chalk on your own step next, then a scored loaf before baking. Note where each mark went and what washed or wore away, because the hand keeps what the eye only borrows. Work no larger than your palm until the turn sits in your wrist.

Lore Root: triskele La Tene-attested — Attested; triquetra-as-druidic — cut, Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Before you draw your triskele, how would you describe it in words, and which way do its arms turn?*

Draw-your-triskele, page one: copy the spiral slowly. Where did your attention break?

Draw-your-triskele, page two: trace what threes matter to you — land, sea, sky, or your own.

Carve-draw tracker: where did your triskele go this month?

- ☐ Paper copy — date
- ☐ Doorway chalk — date
- ☐ Bread scored — date
- ☐ Stitched or drawn on cloth — date
- ☐ Garden or path marking — date
- ☐ Gift given with the mark — date
- ☐ What held, what washed away?

Gaulish words in Latin books

Inside a physician's handbook written in Latin around the year 400, a learned Gaul named Marcellus of Bordeaux tucked charms in his own native tongue among the prescriptions. The Gaulish words sit beside remedies for throat trouble, notes on amulets and stones, and gifts laid in wells: empire medicine with a Gaulish accent. Charms, the page proves, were spoken aloud as well as made with hands. A Gaulish voice survives inside the empire's handbook, prescribing in two tongues at once. His Gaulish survivals cluster around throat troubles, small spoken words set down amid the Latin page.

Surviving Gaulish words lean toward protection and healing, and this chapter follows that line only. Three workings stand here, and every one of them wards and blesses: a knot for the road, a bag for the door, a blessing of water. Nothing here curses or hexes, because that is not the shelf this book keeps. Ward the body, bless the house, guard the road: those three verbs are the whole vocabulary here.

Name one part of your life that needs guarding this week: sleep, the commute, an elder's room. Write it in a single line, leaving defeating and fixing out of the sentence. That line will feed whichever of the three workings you choose to make first. Keep the sentence where you will see it while you work, pinned above the table or first in the journal.

Lore Root: Marcellus charms and amulets — Attested.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *What part of your life needs protecting now, rather than anything you wish to defeat?*

Caim and lorica

Draw a ring around someone with your feet and your voice. The caim is an encircling prayer from Irish tradition: you walk sunwise around a person or a place, speaking protection as you go, until the circle closes. Beside it stands the lorica, the breastplate, a prayer that clothes the body part by part in verse, head to foot, as though dressing it in armor for the day. The turn runs sunwise, with the road of the sun, and the closing thanks seals the ring like a knot.

Both shapes come down through manuscript and folk keeping, attested across prayers and custom rather than invented here. Their household sense is plain: the ring says this ground is watched, the breastplate says this body is dressed. Hallway, garden bed, and your own bedside all take the ring kindly, and your own frame takes the verses well before sleep. Walk it for another person and the meaning doubles: you lend your feet to their guarding.

Walk one small caim tonight around a single room, speaking plain protection as you circle, and close it with thanks at the door. Tomorrow name your own breastplate head to foot in six short lines. One room, one body, under twenty minutes, and the shape is yours to keep. Log where you walked and what words you used; the ring grows stronger each time you close it. A week of small rings will teach you more than one grand one.

Lore Root: caim and lorica prayers — Attested folk and manuscript tradition.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *In plain words, what would your own breastplate prayer name from head to foot?*

First working: the knot charm

Wool or linen cord and three slow knots are the whole toolkit. Folk custom across many districts ties protection into knots, and this working keeps that shape: one line of blessing spoken over each knot as your fingers pull it snug. Give the first knot to the body, the second to the home, the third to the road, speaking each line aloud as you tie. Speak on the out-breath as the knot tightens, so voice and hands finish together. Three knots, three lines, three takings-care.

Knot-tying for protection is a folk survival, gathered from many households rather than prescribed in one rite, and this monthly shape is a modern keeping built upon it. A charm left unwatched grows stale the way bread does, so the rite includes its own renewal: untie at each fire festival and tie fresh, speaking the lines anew. The retying is the devotion, not an afterthought. Date the tying on a tag or in the margin, so the festival finds you ready.

Draft three lines short enough to say in one breath each, and tie your cord at the table tonight. Carry it in a pocket or hang it where trouble tends to enter: the draughty window, the bag you commute with. Twenty minutes with hands and voice, and it is done. Hang it high enough that daily brushing does not wear it thin. When the cord frays, wash it and begin again; worn fiber has simply carried its share.

Lore Root: knot-tying across folk custom — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Draft your three short knot lines here, keeping each one brief enough to speak aloud.*

Second working: the doorway bag

Above your lintel a small bag can keep the household names. Sew or tie a pouch from scrap cloth and fill it with rowan berries or a twig where rowan grows, a pinch of salt, a sprig of vervain, and a slip of paper carrying the names of those under your roof. Hang it inside the door you use most, where your eyes will find it every single day. Keep the stitching plain and the knot firm; a working bag wants honesty, not finery. A thimbleful of salt is plenty; the bag is a token, not a storehouse.

Rowan at the threshold, salt at the sill, green over the door: these ingredients recur across folk custom, gathered from many households rather than one old recipe. The seasonal renewal is modern housekeeping with an old accent, fresh salt and fresh green at each fire festival, names spoken aloud as you set them back. Clearing away the old with care matters as much as hanging the new. Speak each name as you lay the paper back inside, so no one is housed unnamed.

Make the bag in half an hour with needle or string and whatever your shops can supply. Carry the old salt to running water or bare soil when you renew, never the bin beside the door. List your contents and names in the journal tonight so the next renewal finds them ready. The old green goes to soil or running water with thanks, never to the bin.

Lore Root: doorway ingredients across folk custom — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *List what your bag will hold, and write the names that will rest on its paper.*

Third working: the well-water blessing

Clean water in a small bottle can carry the well to your rooms. Fetch it from your own tap with thanks, or from a well where you have asked leave and taken only a little. Keep it sealed and set apart for blessings. A few drops flicked sunwise around a room, across a threshold, or upon a brow, the old pattern called aspersion, lays the water's memory in household miniature. Label the bottle and keep it high, away from drinking vessels and small hands.

This working is reconstructed from well-custom rather than copied from one single rite: the asking of leave, the small taking, the sunwise turn. Its rule is thrift. Never drink from wild water, never bottle from a protected spring, never take more than the blessing needs. Change the water each month and pour what is left on the roots of a plant, so nothing is wasted and nothing harmed. Little and often is the whole method: drops, not draughts. A bottle kept a month and renewed teaches thrift better than any rule.

Choose where the bottle will live and what it will bless first: the desk, the sickroom door, your own forehead before a hard day. The rite takes minutes: open, flick, thank, close. Log the first blessing with its date, and renew the water when the month turns. Bless the threshold first where you are unsure; the door you keep is hungry for it.

Lore Root: water-aspersion pattern — Reconstructed from well-custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Where will your blessing water live, and what will it bless first?*

Charm log: which working did you make, when, and for whom? Record all three.

Protection log: what did you protect this week — body, home, road? Name it.

Uncrossing and repair

Charms fade, snag, or get overrun, and that is maintenance calling, not failure. Folk keeping expects renewal the way houses expect dusting. To uncross a working, take it apart kindly: untie the knot and wash the cord, empty the bag and sweep the sill, pour out the water and scrub the bottle. Name what slipped as you work, without shame and without hurry. Work in daylight with the windows open, and let the taking-apart feel like tidying, because it is.

Remake the thing one size steadier than before: a stronger line on the knot, a better-kept round at the door, a caim walked weekly for a while instead of monthly. The renewal pattern is reconstructed from custom, and this repair-rite shape is modern, labeled so. Repair outranks perfection every time; the mending carries your care forward farther than a flawless first try. Write the repair beside the original entry, so the charm carries its history with it. Failure logged honestly beats perfection pretended.

Look over your rooms tonight and find one working that needs it. Give it twenty minutes: uncross, clean, remake, log. Write what slipped in one line and what steadies it in the next. The house will feel the difference by morning. Thank the working as you close it, stale or steady; gratitude mends faster than fault-finding. Begin tonight, while the need is fresh.

Lore Root: renewal pattern — Reconstructed; repair-rite — Modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Look around your house. What needs uncrossing, and what is its very first step?*

Home ward tracker, week one: walk the caim, mark the day.

- ☐ Day 1 — walked?
- ☐ Day 2 — walked?
- ☐ Day 3 — walked?
- ☐ Day 4 — walked?
- ☐ Day 5 — walked?
- ☐ Day 6 — walked?
- ☐ Day 7 — walked + knot re-tied?
- ☐ What held this week?

Home ward tracker, week two: walk the caim, mark the day.

- ☐ Day 8 — walked?
- ☐ Day 9 — walked?
- ☐ Day 10 — walked?
- ☐ Day 11 — walked?
- ☐ Day 12 — walked?
- ☐ Day 13 — walked?
- ☐ Day 14 — walked + bag renewed?
- ☐ What held across both weeks?

Tech Duinn and the mounds

Far to the southwest, the old Irish tales say, lies the house of Donn, Tech Duinn, a dark island where the dead gather to rest. Closer to home, the grass-covered mounds with their stone doors were honored as kindly portals, said to stand open at Samhain so those gone before could draw near. Your people are not far off in this telling, more like neighbors toward dusk, within calling distance of the table. Say the name Tech Duinn aloud once, and feel how the syllables land like stones in deep water.

Hold that nearness gently, as comfort rather than claim. The island and the open mounds come from the tales, an attested literary pattern rather than a map you could sail. Nothing here asks you to prove or perform anything. One shared meal a year, a card or two, a letter, a roll call of names: small vessels, and grief is welcome at the table with its manners intact. Come as you are, grieving or steady or numb; the table does not grade your feelings.

Rest with one name tonight, with no rite required at all. Light a candle if you like, speak the name aloud, and remember one true thing about them. Write that single sentence down before sleep. When you are ready, the supper page will show you the fuller keeping. There is no test to pass and nothing to get right, only a name spoken and a sentence kept.

Lore Root: Tech Duinn and mound-portals in the tales — Attested literary pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Rest a moment. Which of your dead feels nearest to you right now?*

The dumb supper script

Lay one more plate than the living need, and keep the first half of the meal in silence. A dumb supper is a quiet supper shared with the dead: cook a full meal you can manage, set the extra place with care, light a candle for each name you will speak. Eat together in kind, companionable quiet, letting the empty chair hold its own at the table. Keep the food simple and hot: soup, bread, something from their table where you know it.

Halfway through, speak each name aloud with one true sentence, thanks or memory or something left unsaid, and eat the second half carrying them with you. The shape comes down through folk custom, kept in many households in many forms, and this script is one gentle modern keeping of it. Once a year is plenty. Steady remembrance outweighs grandeur, and tears at the table are no breach of manners. Let silence do the heavy lifting; you need no speech beyond the names and one true sentence.

After the meal, thank them for coming and snuff the candles. Set a portion aside for birds or neighbors in the morning. The whole keeping fits inside an hour, dishes aside. Choose your menu and your names tonight, and let the page hold them until the night arrives. Sleep with the names written beside the bed, and notice what morning brings. Keep the night unhurried; the dead are patient company.

Lore Root: dumb-supper shape — Folk survival.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *What will your supper menu be, and which names do you wish to invite?*

Ancestor card, first: name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, one question.

Ancestor card, second: name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, one question.

Grief letter plus roll-call: write the unsent letter, then list your Samhain names.

Your vow page: fill it in. I will keep ___ for 30 days. I will not ___. Witnessed by ___.

Thirty-day integration tracker: one line a day across realm, fire, plant, and charm.

- ☐ Days 1-5: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ Days 6-10: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ Days 11-15: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ Days 16-20: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ Days 21-25: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ Days 26-30: realm checked? fire kept? plant seen? charm held?
- ☐ What held all month?
- ☐ What lapsed, and what repairs it?

Go on reading

Four old books can carry your thread past this one, and each is best met in small bites through public translations you can borrow before buying. The Tain, the Irish cattle-raid tale, opens at its ford fights. The Mabinogi, a Welsh collection, begins with Pwyll and Rhiannon in its First Branch. The Book of Invasions tells who came to Ireland wave by wave, and the great battle-tale of the gods closes the shelf with thunder. Borrow before buying, and read with a pencil: the margins of old tales reward plain questions.

Meet them as stories first and lessons second, a chapter at a time with your pen nearby. These are attested primary texts in translation, not summaries, and they reward slow going. Take notes the way this book taught you: what happened, what it means at home, what small act answers it. Let each tale settle a week before you judge it. A chapter a week is a good pace; these books have waited centuries and will wait for you.

Commit to one book and one starting day, and begin the next morning in the same spot with the same plain speech. An hour or less a sitting is plenty. Go in peace from these pages, and keep the door you have tended so well. Lend this book onward when you are done, and tell the next reader which page held you longest. The shelf will still be there when the thirty days are done.

Lore Root: primary texts to read next — Attested, go meet them.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
> *Which book will you open first, and on what day will you begin?*